

NEXTSTEPS 101

(1 of 8)

BLUE – POWER POINT PRESENTATION

BROWN – INSTRUCTIONS TO TECHNICIAN

TEXT: [Hebrews 10:19-25](#) (NKJV) *"Therefore, brethren, having boldness to enter the Holiest by the blood of Jesus,²⁰ by a new and living way which He consecrated for us, through the veil, that is, His flesh,²¹ and having a High Priest over the house of God,²² let us draw near with a true heart in full assurance of faith, having our hearts sprinkled from an evil conscience and our bodies washed with pure water.²³ Let us hold fast the confession of our hope without wavering, for He who promised is faithful.²⁴ And let us consider one another in order to stir up love and good works,²⁵ not forsaking the assembling of ourselves together, as is the manner of some, but exhorting one another, and so much the more as you see the Day approaching."*

[Luke 4:14-16](#) (NKJV) *"Then Jesus returned in the power of the Spirit to Galilee, and news of Him went out through all the surrounding region.¹⁵ And He taught in their synagogues, being glorified by all. ¹⁶ So He came to Nazareth, where He had been brought up. And as His custom was, He went into the synagogue on the Sabbath day, and stood up to read."*

[Acts 3:1-9](#) (NKJV) *"Now Peter and John went up together to the temple at the hour of prayer, the ninth hour.² And a certain man lame from his mother's womb was carried, whom they laid daily at the gate of the temple which is called Beautiful, to ask alms from those who entered the temple;³ who, seeing Peter and John about to go into the temple, asked for alms.⁴ And fixing his eyes on him, with John, Peter said, "Look at us."⁵ So he gave them his attention, expecting to receive something from them.⁶ Then Peter said, "Silver and gold I do not have, but what I do have I give you: In the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, rise up and walk."⁷ And he took him by the right hand and lifted him up, and immediately his feet and ankle bones received strength.⁸ So he, leaping up, stood and walked and entered the temple with them—walking, leaping, and praising God.⁹ And all the people saw him walking and praising God."*

INTRO: I am convinced; most Christians desire to live an overcoming life. Because this is our desire we normally make an attempt to do the things we believe will produce such a life. Oftentimes the problem with carrying out such intentions is simply the lack of knowledge for why we do such things. I was raised in church

but I knew more about what we did not believe, than what we did believe, and why.

In this series of lessons we will look at the steps a person should take to live an overcoming Christian life: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Church attendance
- Prayer
- Reading the Bible
- Following Jesus in water baptism
- Receiving the Holy Spirit
- Living a life of service
- Personal evangelism
- Becoming a tither

CHURCH ATTENDANCE

(My history) In forty nine years of living on this earth there has never been a time when I was not "In Church":

- I was raised in a church!
- I was dedicated to the Lord in a church!
- I was saved in a church!
- I was baptized in water in a church!
- I was received into membership in a church!
- Susan and I were married in a church!
- We dedicated our children in a church!
- We have raised our family in a church!
- My funeral will be held in a church!

I am literally a product of the church. Because I am a product of the church, I am a champion of the church. I would fight hell with a water pistol in defense of the church!

I know there are some stinkers (Hypocrites) in the church but Noah had a couple of stinkers (Skunks) on his boat as well, but it was the best thing afloat!

Jesus went to church. Luke 4:16 (NKJV) ***"So He came to Nazareth, where He had been brought up. And as His custom was, He went into the synagogue on the Sabbath day, ..."***

The apostles went to church. Acts 3:1 (NKJV) "Now Peter and John went up together to the temple at the hour of prayer, ..."

We are commanded to go to church. Hebrews 10:25 (NKJV) "Not forsaking the assembling of ourselves together, as is the manner of some, but exhorting one another, and so much the more as you see the Day approaching."

There are sins of omission and sins of commission, if I disobey a command I have sinned! We have been commanded to go to church, not to do so would be to commit sin.

The example of church attendance by Jesus and His disciples, as well as the scriptural commandment for us to attend church more regularly as we see the end time approaching is surely based on more than an effort to give us something to do to occupy our time! There are many reasons for a mandate concerning church attendance; I want us to focus on seven of them...

WE SHOULD ATTEND CHURCH TO BE FED SPIRITUALLY!

People have various opinions of what the responsibilities of the Pastor should be but the Word of God makes it clear that his primary responsibility is: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- **To feed the flock!** - John 21:15-17 (NKJV) "*So when they had eaten breakfast, Jesus said to Simon Peter, **“Simon, son of Jonah, do you love Me more than these?”** He said to Him, “Yes, Lord; You know that I love You.” He said to him, **“Feed My lambs.”**¹⁶ He said to him again a second time, **“Simon, son of Jonah, do you love Me?”** He said to Him, “Yes, Lord; You know that I love You.” He said to him, **“Tend My sheep.”**¹⁷ He said to him the third time, **“Simon, son of Jonah, do you love Me?”** Peter was grieved because He said to him the third time, “Do you love Me?” And he said to Him, “Lord, You know all things; You know that I love You.” Jesus said to him, **“Feed My sheep.”***"
- **To preach and teach the Word of God!** - Acts 6:1-4 (NKJV) "*Now in those days, when the number of the disciples was multiplying, there arose a complaint against the Hebrews by the Hellenists, because their widows were neglected in the daily distribution.² Then the twelve summoned the multitude of the disciples and said, **“It is not desirable that we should leave the word of God and serve tables.”**³ “Therefore, brethren, seek out from among you seven men of good reputation, full of the Holy Spirit and*

wisdom, whom we may appoint over this business;4 “but we will give ourselves continually to prayer and to the ministry of the word.”

- To equip God’s people for works of ministry! - Ephesians 4:11-13 (NKJV)
"And He Himself gave some to be apostles, some prophets, some evangelists, and some pastors and teachers,12 for the equipping of the saints for the work of ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ,13 till we all come to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, to a perfect man, to the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ."

If we are a faithful church attendee and the pastor discharges his responsibly he will not only preach to us but teach us line upon line, precept upon precept, all the while building us up in our most Holy faith. The first step to living a successful Christian life is to attend church faithfully.

If we attend church faithfully we will be surprised at how often the word of God will discern what we are dealing with or anticipate what we will be dealing with. Hebrews 4:12 (NKJV) *"For the word of God is living and powerful, and sharper than any two-edged sword, piercing even to the division of soul and spirit, and of joints and marrow, and is a discerner of the thoughts and intents of the heart."*

WE SHOULD ATTEND CHURCH TO FUNCTION AS A BODY!

When we connect ourselves as we should to a local church it helps us realize we are a part of something bigger than we are. Being connected to a local church aids us in our attempt to understand what it means to be a part of the corporate or triumphant church. Matthew 16:18 ***“And I also say to you that you are Peter, and on this rock I will build My church, and the gates of Hades shall not prevail against it.”***

Being connected to the local church points up the fact, we should make a contribution to other believers, by offering up our abilities in service to them.

When we are a faithful part of the local church we become aware of the importance of every other member of the local church. 1 Corinthians 12:18-20, 27 (NKJV) ***“But now God has set the members, each one of them, in the body just as He pleased.19 And if they were all one member, where would the body be?20 But now indeed there are many members, yet one body. - 27 Now you are the body of Christ, and members individually.”*** Every member of the body is vitally important.

WE SHOULD ATTEND CHURCH TO BE UNDER SPIRITUAL AUTHORITY!

All authority comes from the Lord. When we connect to a proper local church we will be taught to submit to both civil and spiritual authority! All of us have a need to be under authority. Matthew 8:5-13 (NKJV) *"Now when Jesus had entered Capernaum, a centurion came to Him, pleading with Him,⁶ saying, 'Lord, my servant is lying at home paralyzed, dreadfully tormented.'⁷ And Jesus said to him, **'I will come and heal him.'**⁸ The centurion answered and said, 'Lord, I am not worthy that You should come under my roof. But only speak a word, and my servant will be healed.⁹ 'For I also am a man under authority, having soldiers under me. And I say to this one, 'Go,' and he goes; and to another, 'Come,' and he comes; and to my servant, 'Do this,' and he does it.'¹⁰ When Jesus heard it, He marveled, and said to those who followed, **"Assuredly, I say to you, I have not found such great faith, not even in Israel!**¹¹ **"And I say to you that many will come from east and west, and sit down with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob in the kingdom of heaven.¹² "But the sons of the kingdom will be cast out into outer darkness. There will be weeping and gnashing of teeth."¹³ Then Jesus said to the centurion, **"Go your way; and as you have believed, so let it be done for you."** And his servant was healed that same hour."***

Faithful church attendance teaches us the need to submit to spiritual authority. **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)** We come to realize God has placed a line of authority within the local church for its proper governance:

- Jesus is the good Shepherd!
- The Pastor is the under shepherd!
- Local leaders are called alongside the Pastor for the purpose of implementing the vision God has given to the Pastor!

Any kind of variance from this scriptural model leads to anarchy and division!

When we are closely enough connected to the local church to see its proper operation it gives us a model to govern our families.

Everyone needs accountability! Power corrupts, but absolute power, absolutely corrupts!

WE SHOULD ATTEND CHURCH FOR THE OPPORTUNITY TO SERVE!

A call to follow Jesus is synonymous with a call to service. When Jesus called His disciples he said, *"Follow me and I will make you fishers of men."*

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

We are to serve in the following ways:

- Serve God - One way of serving God is to worship Him.
- Serve others - Matthew 25:34-40 (NKJV) *“Then the King will say to those on His right hand, ‘Come, you blessed of My Father, inherit the kingdom prepared for you from the foundation of the world:35 ‘for I was hungry and you gave Me food; I was thirsty and you gave Me drink; I was a stranger and you took Me in;36 ‘I was naked and you clothed Me; I was sick and you visited Me; I was in prison and you came to Me.’37 “Then the righteous will answer Him, saying, ‘Lord, when did we see You hungry and feed You, or thirsty and give You drink?38 ‘When did we see You a stranger and take You in, or naked and clothe You?39 ‘Or when did we see You sick, or in prison, and come to You?’40 “And the King will answer and say to them, ‘Assuredly, I say to you, inasmuch as you did it to one of the least of these My brethren, you did it to Me.”*
- Serve the world - John 3:16 (NKJV) *“For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life.”*

We cannot fulfill our purpose without satisfying these three things.

All three of these areas of service can be performed more effectively when the believer is working in conjunction with the local church.

WE SHOULD ATTEND CHURCH FOR THE OPPORTUNITY TO DEVELOP OUR GIFTS!

Every believer has natural gifts and abilities that they were born with. The reason we were born with these abilities is because they will fold perfectly into the spiritual gifts God will give us as we attempt to fulfill the purpose of God for our lives.

The best place on the planet for developing our gifts is the local church. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** Think of all the movie stars and recording artists that got their start in the church:

- Elvis Presley
- Dolly Parton
- Reba McEntire
- The Gatlin Brothers

- Naomi Judd
- Charlie Daniels
- Usher
- Ludicrous
- Good Charlotte
- Mandy Moore
- Outcast Kanye (Con-yea) West
- Jessica and Ashley Simpson (Their dad was a preacher)

I would be afraid to have my gifts developed in the church and then use them in the world.

The development of our gifts is the process of walking out our destiny. We are following HIM one step at a time as HE develops us; moves us closer to our destiny; and then takes us to the next level of development which was no doubt His original intention. 2 Peter 3:18 (NKJV) "**Grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ...**"

WE SHOULD ATTEND CHURCH TO SHARE IN WORLD EVANGELISM!

The will of God for every believer and every church is the pooling of our efforts and finances in an attempt to evangelize the world. Mark 16:15 (NKJV) "***And He said to them, Go into all the world and preach the gospel to every creature.***"

WE SHOULD ATTEND CHURCH TO RECEIVE THE MINISTRY GIFTS OF OTHERS!

No person is an island to themselves. We all need to serve others but we all need to be served by others as well. Believers who attempt to live their lives solo miss the blessing of serving and being served. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)**

ILLUSTRATION:

A member of a certain church, who previously had been attending services regularly, suddenly stopped coming to church. After a few weeks, the Pastor decided to visit.

The Pastor found the man at home alone, sitting before a blazing fire. Guessing the reason for his Pastor's visit, the man welcomed him, led him to a comfortable chair near the fireplace and waited. The pastor made himself at home but said

nothing. In the grave silence, he contemplated the dance of the flames around the burning logs.

After some minutes, the Pastor took the fire tongs, carefully picked up a brightly burning ember and placed it to one side of the hearth all alone. Then he sat back in his chair, still silent. The host watched all this in quiet contemplation. As the one lone ember's flame flickered and diminished, there was a momentary glow and then its fire was no more. Soon it was cold and lifeless. The Pastor glanced at his watch and realized it was time to leave; he slowly stood up, picked up the cold, dead ember and placed it back in the middle of the fire. Immediately it began to glow, once more with the light and warmth of the burning coals around it. As the Pastor reached the door to leave, his host said with a tear running down his cheek, "Thank you so much for your visit and especially for the fiery sermon. I will be back in church next Sunday."

God ordained the church for the purpose of ministering to the saints and reaching the world. We cannot very well reach the world if we are not receiving ministry from others.

What better place to receive ministry than the local church?

Take a moment to think about what kind of a Christians we would be if the following were not available to us: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- No other Christians to fellowship with
- No teachers to teach us
- No discipleship to train us
- No Pastor to shepherd us; counsel us; marry us; or bury us

CONCLUSION:

I want to close with this question:

(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN FOR THE REMAINDER OF THE SESSION)

What kind of church would this church be, if every member were just like me?

Can we commit ourselves today to making this a much better church by being faithful with our attendance? The first step of living a successful Christian life is to connect oneself to a church and to attend faithfully.

FACILITATOR'S QUESTIONS:

- 1) Who is over all local churches?
- 2) Who is the human authority in the local church?
- 3) Should one commit to a local church, or is it acceptable to attend more than one church at a time?
- 4) What would be a suitable reason for being absent from church?
- 5) Is it ever appropriate for a Christian to intentionally be absent from church for an extended period of time?
- 6) What factors should a person consider when attempting to find a good local church to attend?

NEXTSTEPS 101

PRAYER

(2 of 8)

BLUE – POWER POINT PRESENTATION

BROWN – INSTRUCTIONS TO TECHNICIAN

TEXT: Luke 18:1-5 (NKJV) *"Then He spoke a parable to them, that men always ought to pray and not lose heart,² saying: ***“There was in a certain city a judge who did not fear God nor regard man.***³ ***“Now there was a widow in that city; and she came to him, saying, ‘Get justice for me from my adversary.’***⁴ ***“And he would not for a while; but afterward he said within himself, ‘Though I do not fear God nor regard man,***⁵ ***‘yet because this widow troubles me I will avenge her, lest by her continual coming she weary me.’***”*

Matthew 7:7-8 (NKJV) ***“Ask, and it will be given to you; seek, and you will find; knock, and it will be opened to you.***⁸ ***“For everyone who asks receives, and he who seeks finds, and to him who knocks it will be opened.”***

Ephesians 6:18-20 (NKJV) ***“Praying always with all prayer and supplication in the Spirit, being watchful to this end with all perseverance and supplication for all the saints—*¹⁹ ***and for me, that utterance may be given to me, that I may open my mouth boldly to make known the mystery of the gospel,***²⁰ ***for which I am an ambassador in chains; that in it I may speak boldly, as I ought to speak.”*****

INTRO: Prayer is a subject that transcends all religious barriers. Every religion has their own idea of the proper means, times and reasons for prayer.

Various religions pray to a diversity of gods: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Muslim and Islamic believers pray to Allah, five times a day
- Buddhist believers pray to Buddha
- Hindu believers pray to hundreds of gods, two times a day
- Jewish believers pray to Yahweh, three times a day
- Catholics pray to Mary
- All Christians pray to Jehovah, the one true God

The thing that sets the prayers of the Christian apart from all others is that other religions pray to dead deities, we pray to THE God who is very much alive. (My dad once had a bumper sticker on his vehicle that said: *"My God's not dead, sorry about yours!"*)

Peter Kreeft, Author and professor of theology at Boston College made this observation concerning prayer: *"I strongly suspect that if we saw all the difference even the tiniest of our prayers make, and all the people those little prayers were destined to affect, and all the consequences of those prayers down through the centuries, we would be so paralyzed with awe at the power of prayer that we would be unable to get up off of our knees for the rest of our lives."*

The Word of God makes it clear; [prayer is the act of communicating with God.](#) **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** When teaching believers to pray Jesus said, *"Our Father which art in Heaven..."* If prayer is the means of communication between an earthly believer and his Heavenly Father the earthly believer should look forward to speaking with his Father/Mentor!

We should pray for the following reasons...

PRAYER IS REQUIRED TO BE FORGIVEN!

Psalm 32:1-6 (NKJV) *"A Psalm of David. Blessed is he whose transgression is forgiven, Whose sin is covered. 2 Blessed is the man to whom the LORD does not impute iniquity, And in whose spirit there is no deceit. 3 When I kept silent, my bones grew old Through my groaning all the day long. 4 For day and night Your hand was heavy upon me; My vitality was turned into the drought of summer. Selah 5 I acknowledged my sin to You, And my iniquity I have not hidden. I said, "I will confess my transgressions to the LORD," And You forgave the iniquity of my sin. Selah 6 For this cause everyone who is godly shall pray to You In a time when You may be found; Surely in a flood of great waters They shall not come near him."* Please allow me to paraphrase verses 1 and two: *"Happy; fortunate; to be envied; is the person whose transgressions are forgiven; whose sins are covered; toward whom the Lord does not keep a record of wrongs committed; in whose spirit there is no deceit."* The Hemphills made popular a song that said, *"I'm not perfect, just forgiven..."*

The greatest miracle that could ever be performed is for God to forgive a sin.

[The process of forgiveness looks like this:](#) **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- [Acknowledgement](#) - Forgiveness of sins begins with an individual verbalizing (praying) his sinful condition. Vs. 5 *"I acknowledged my sin to You..."*
- [Confession](#) - Vs. 5 *"I will confess my transgressions to the LORD..."*
- [Forgiveness](#) - Vs.5 *"You forgave the iniquity of my sin."*

The Psalmist states that as long as he kept silent he grew increasingly more miserable (Probably because of conviction). Vs. 3&4 *"When I kept silent, my bones grew old Through my groaning all the day long. 4 For day and night Your hand was heavy upon me; My vitality was turned into the drought of summer."*

Notice what he states the end result will be. Vs. 6 *"For this cause everyone who is godly shall pray to You In a time when You may be found; Surely in a flood of great waters They shall not come near him."*

We should pray continually to be sure we do not harbor [un-confessed](#) sin.

PRAYER IS REQUIRED TO DEVELOP AN INTIMATE RELATIONSHIP WITH GOD!

Psalm 116:1-9 (LB) *"I love the Lord because he hears my prayers and answers them. 2 Because he bends down and listens, I will pray as long as I breathe! 3 Death stared me in the face—I was frightened and sad. 4 Then I cried, "Lord, save me!" 5 How kind he is! How good he is! So merciful, this God of ours! 6 The Lord protects the simple and the childlike; I was facing death, and then he saved me. 7 Now I can relax. For the Lord has done this wonderful miracle for me. 8 He has saved me from death, my eyes from tears, my feet from stumbling. 9 I shall live! Yes, in his presence—here on earth!"*

The writer here lets us know that he is a praying person and the habit of prayer has caused him to know that God hears and answers prayer. Vs. 1 *"I love the Lord because he hears my prayers and answers them."*

The practice of prayer led to an intimate relationship between God and the Psalmist. Vs. 2 *"He bends down and listens..."*

For the believer, all intimacy is born out of trust. Through his prayer life the Psalmist learned to trust God. Vs. 3-9 *"Death stared me in the face—I was frightened and sad. 4 Then I cried, "Lord, save me!" 5 How kind he is! How good he is! So merciful, this God of ours! 6 The Lord protects the simple and the childlike; I was facing death, and then he saved me. 7 Now I can relax. For the Lord has done this wonderful miracle for me. 8 He has saved me from death, my*

eyes from tears, my feet from stumbling. 9 I shall live! Yes, in his presence—here on earth!"

We should practice prayer for the purpose of developing intimacy with God.

PRAYER IS REQUIRED TO MAINTAIN PURITY!

A believer can lose out with God doing just about anything in the church. Believers who have a daily prayer time which they are faithful to, never backslide!

When we are tempted to sin the fact that we know we are meeting with God the next morning keeps us from committing sin. A believer who is consistent in prayer knows; sin causes them to dread their prayer time. Psalm 24:3-4 (NLT) ***"Who may climb the mountain of the LORD? Who may stand in his holy place? 4 Only those whose hands and hearts are pure, who do not worship idols and never tell lies."***

Daily prayer produces purity in our lives. Holiness is still the order of the day! Matthew 5:8 (NKJV) ***"Blessed are the pure in heart, For they shall see God."***

We should develop a consistent prayer life in an effort of maintaining a life of purity! **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** 1 John 3:2-3 (NKJV) ***"Beloved, now we are children of God; and it has not yet been revealed what we shall be, but we know that when He is revealed, we shall be like Him, for we shall see Him as He is.³ And everyone who has this hope in Him purifies himself, just as He is pure."***

PRAYER IS REQUIRED TO WALK IN FAITH!

Faith is a very important component in the life of a believer. Hebrews 11:6 (KJV) ***"But without faith it is impossible to please him: for he that cometh to God must believe that he is, and that he is a rewarder of them that diligently seek him."***

Prayer is essential in the development of faith. Matthew 21:21-22 (NKJV) ***"So Jesus answered and said to them, "Assuredly, I say to you, if you have faith and do not doubt, you will not only do what was done to the fig tree, but also if you say to this mountain, 'Be removed and be cast into the sea,' it will be done."²² "And whatever things you ask in prayer, believing, you will receive."***

Every believer begins their spiritual walk with exactly the same amount of faith. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** Romans 12:3 (NKJV) ***"... God has dealt to each one a measure of faith."*** Romans 12:3 (KJV)

"... God hath dealt to every man the measure of faith." The level of faith a believer is capable of attaining depends how he goes about exercising his faith.

The exercising of faith is directly tied to our prayer life! James 1:5-7 (NKJV) ***"If any of you lacks wisdom, let him ask of God, who gives to all liberally and without reproach, and it will be given to him.***⁶ ***But let him ask in faith, with no doubting, for he who doubts is like a wave of the sea driven and tossed by the wind.***⁷ ***For let not that man suppose that he will receive anything from the Lord."***

We should pray, making our requests known to God. When He answers our prayer, our faith rises to a new level. Each prayer that we see answered enables us to believe God for larger things. As we walk this process out, we are pleasing God! **We should develop a prayer life in an effort of growing our faith!**

PRAYER IS REQUIRED TO WALK IN FREEDOM!

We live in a world that is in bondage on many fronts. People are grappling with addictions and phobias of all kinds. Sadly, the bondage of believers oftentimes mirrors that of the world. These things can be broken through the power of prayer.

Psalms 34 lays out the freedom God affords through prayer. Psalm 34:4 (NLT) ***"I prayed to the LORD, and he answered me, freeing me from all my fears."*** I do not have time to read the entire chapter but I would like us to quickly examine several truths. In this passage we are told that **the Lord will do the following things in response to the prayer of the believer:** **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Deliver us from fear - Vs. 4
- Save us from our trouble - Vs.6
- Guard and deliver us - Vs. 7
- Be good to those who trust in Him - Vs. 8
- Supply all needs - Vs. 9
- Hear us when we pray - Vs. 15
- Redeem us - Vs. 22

We are to receive these things through: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Crying out to Him - Vs. 6&17
- Trusting Him - Vs. 8
- Fearing Him - Vs. 7&9
- Refraining from lying - Vs. 13

- [Humbling ourselves](#) - Vs. 18
- [Serving Him](#) - Vs. 18

God promises great blessings to his people, but many of these blessings require our active participation. In this instance our participation is a consistent prayer life. Prayer is a requirement of living an overcoming Christian life.

If we hope to live free we must be people of [prayer](#).

PRAYER IS REQUIRED TO PERSEVERE!

My definition of persistence is [the steadfast determination](#) to complete a task without regard to the sacrifice.

By its nature the Christian life demands a boatload of persistence. Any achievement worthy of the effort it requires, merits the investment of persistence. I believe [two things are required for a Christian to make the commitment necessary to persist in achieving the will of God:](#) **(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- [Become people of prayer](#) - Persistent people are prayerful people... Prayerlessness produces a lack of persistence... The reason? Because persistence is born out of intimacy; intimacy with God is not possible without a prayer life...
- [Know whom we serve and whose vision we are striving for](#)... 2 Timothy 1:11-14 (NKJV) *"... I am appointed a preacher, an apostle, and a teacher of the Gentiles.12 For this reason I also suffer these things; nevertheless I am not ashamed, for I know whom I have believed and am persuaded that He is able to keep what I have committed to Him until that Day. 13 Hold fast the pattern of sound words which you have heard from me, in faith and love which are in Christ Jesus.14 That good thing which was committed to you, keep by the Holy Spirit who dwells in us."*

Winston Churchill said, *"The reason a bulldog's nose is slanted backward is so he can breathe while he holds on!"* The church has far too many figureheads, deadheads and hotheads! We must become people who have hearts ablaze to do the will of God! We must have bull dog tenacity in pursuing the purposes of God!

We should pray because it will cause us to be [steady](#) and persistent!

PRAYER IS REQUIRED TO HAVE POWER WITH GOD!

Most people would like to have power with God; so why don't we? There are no shortcuts to God's power supply. **The path to God's power house leads through His prayer room! (LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** No prayer; no power. This probably answers the question heard echoing through churches all across America; *"Where are the miracles? What must we do to see His miracles? Where is His power?"*

Prayer is not a requirement strictly confined to the New Testament! Prior to performing miracles, Moses found it necessary to spend time in the presence of God! Where did God first speak to Moses? On the backside of the desert, alone, in the presence of God! In addition, look at this, Exodus 10:1-2 (NKJV) ***"Now the LORD said to Moses, 'Go in to Pharaoh; for I have hardened his heart and the hearts of his servants, that I may show these signs of Mine before him,² 'and that you may tell in the hearing of your son and your son's son the mighty things I have done in Egypt, and My signs which I have done among them, that you may know that I am the LORD.'***"

Jesus spoke of His desire for His people to continue the string of miracles he had begun. Mark 16:17-18 (NKJV) ***"And these signs will follow those who believe: In My name they will cast out demons; they will speak with new tongues;¹⁸ 'they will take up serpents; and if they drink anything deadly, it will by no means hurt them; they will lay hands on the sick, and they will recover.'***"

Cindy Davis, author and school teacher from Hampton, Virginia, said, *"The most amazing thing about a miracle is that it can't happen until all else has failed. That's God's favorite time to work."*

Why do you suppose God set the distribution of miracles up in a way that they flow through those who pray? **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Praying people are intimately connected to God to the point of developing a heart like Him
- Praying people see things like God sees them
- Praying people hear things like God hears them
- Praying people are humble, not allowing pride to enter when a miracle occurs

The prayers of righteous people are a source of great power to the world. James 5:16-18 (NKJV) ***"Confess your trespasses to one another, and pray for one another, that you may be healed. The effective, fervent prayer of a righteous man***

avails much.¹⁷ Elijah was a man with a nature like ours, and he prayed earnestly that it would not rain; and it did not rain on the land for three years and six months.¹⁸ And he prayed again, and the heaven gave rain, and the earth produced its fruit."

We should pray so we will be capable of allowing God to dispense miracles through us to a world who desperately needs them!

CONCLUSION:

I want to close with a challenge to practical application: Will you commit yourself to begin each day with fifteen minutes of prayer? **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN FOR THE REMAINDER OF THE SESSION)**

If one is to be successful in living in a way which would please the Lord, prayer is essential!

FACILITATOR'S QUESTIONS:

- 1) What are some hindrances to effective prayer?
- 2) What is meant by praying without ceasing?
- 3) How important is corporate prayer in the life of the believer?
- 4) Is corporate prayer more powerful than the prayer of an individual believer?
- 5) How can one be sure one is praying according to will of God?
- 6) Is it ever appropriate for one to pray repeatedly for the same thing?

NEXTSTEPS 101 READING THE BIBLE (3 of 8)

BLUE – POWER POINT PRESENTATION

BROWN – INSTRUCTIONS TO TECHNICIAN

TEXT: [Joshua 1:8](#) (NKJV) *"This Book of the Law shall not depart from your mouth, but you shall meditate in it day and night, that you may observe to do according to all that is written in it. For then you will make your way prosperous, and then you will have good success."*

[Psalm 119:96-106](#) (NKJV) *"I have seen the consummation of all perfection, But Your commandment is exceedingly broad. 97 Oh, how I love Your law! It is my meditation all the day. 98 You, through Your commandments, make me wiser than my enemies; For they are ever with me. 99 I have more understanding than all my teachers, For Your testimonies are my meditation. 100 I understand more than the ancients, Because I keep Your precepts. 101 I have restrained my feet from every evil way, That I may keep Your word. 102 I have not departed from Your judgments, For You Yourself have taught me. 103 How sweet are Your words to my taste, Sweeter than honey to my mouth! 104 Through Your precepts I get understanding; Therefore I hate every false way. 105 Your word is a lamp to my feet And a light to my path. 106 I have sworn and confirmed That I will keep Your righteous judgments."*

Speaking to Judas, not Iscariot, Jesus said, [John 14:23-24](#) (NKJV) ***"If anyone loves Me, he will keep My word; and My Father will love him, and We will come to him and make Our home with him.**24 **"He who does not love Me does not keep My words; and the word which you hear is not Mine but the Father's who sent Me."***

INTRO: The Bible is often referred to as the Word of God. The reason we refer to this book in this way is because that's exactly what it is; The Word of God. Christians who believe the Bible to be the Word of God will automatically esteem the importance of reading it on a regular basis. Every Christian should develop a systematic approach to Bible reading. If it is the Word of God we should read it every day. [The BIBLE can be defined in the following way:](#)

- [B - Basic](#)
- [I – Instruction](#)
- [B – Before](#)

- L – [Leaving](#)
- E- [Earth](#)

The fact that we are all very busy is certainly not lost on me; however, we must carve out some room for the Word of God in our busy schedules. If we do this, we will soon discover that a systematic reading of the Scriptures give answers to current difficulties. [In our daily Bible reading we will receive answers for yesterday's questions.](#) We will also find solutions for tomorrow's [dilemma](#), which we have not yet anticipated. How is this possible? Hebrews 4:12 (NKJV) ***"For the word of God is living and powerful, and sharper than any two-edged sword, piercing even to the division of soul and spirit, and of joints and marrow, and is a discerner of the thoughts and intents of the heart."***

Most of us give very little consideration to the [various food groups](#) while planning our daily menu. We eat and [allow our body to process the nutrients, proteins, and vitamins that it needs.](#) We rarely say: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- I need to eat some [carbohydrates](#) to feed my brain today
- I need to eat some [fruit](#) for the antioxidants; vitamins which they provide
- I need to eat some [vegetables](#) for the fiber which they provide
- I need to eat some [meat & protein](#) - Poultry, fish, dry beans, eggs and nuts for the maintenance of my muscles
- I need to eat some [dairy products](#) today to keep my bones, teeth and nails healthy
- I need to eat some [fats](#) today to line and cushion the internal organs

The human body is an awesome machine. It is capable of taking the food we eat and converting it into what we need to sustain a quality life. It is also capable of dispensing the food we eat to the various areas of our bodies to be processed into brain cells, muscle, vitamins, protein, energy, etc... [When we read the Bible the Spirit becomes the processor sending the Word throughout our entire being, thus supplying all our need!](#) Ephesians 4:16 (NKJV) ***"From whom the whole body, joined and knit together by what every joint supplies, according to the effective working by which every part does its share, causes growth of the body for the edifying of itself in love."***

Though there are hundreds of reasons to consistently read the Word of God, I want to look at just a few of them...

WE SHOULD READ THE BIBLE BECAUSE IT IS DIVINELY INSPIRED AND INFALLIBLE!

In this post-modern culture many religious leaders and denominations are waffling on the issues of inspiration and inerrancy. I want to be very clear on my stand with regard to these issues, I believe the Bible to be both divinely inspired and completely infallible.

If we allow our belief on these two issues to be eroded we fail to have a basis for faith and practice. If we cannot believe in the inspiration and infallibility of Scripture, how can we believe anything the Bible says? In my mind, we must believe all of it, or none of it!

From a practical point of view think of this: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- The Bible contains 66 books, divided into the Old and New Testaments - 39 in the Old and 27 in the New
- The word testament means covenant or contract - The old contract; the new contract
- The Bible was written by more than 40 authors over a time span of 1500 years
- The Bible was written by shepherds, farmers, tent-makers, physicians, fishermen, priests, philosophers and kings; yet it does not contradict itself even once
- The Bible has been translated into more than 2,000 languages, with countless more partial translations, and audio translations - In comparison, Shakespeare, considered by many to be the master writer of the English language, has only been translated into 50 languages
- The Bible is still the best seller of all time

From a spiritual point of view the Bible states its own divine inspiration and infallibility: **(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- 2 Timothy 3:16 (NKJV) "All Scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness, 17 that the man of God may be complete, thoroughly equipped for every good work."
- 2 Peter 1:21 (KJV) "For the prophecy came not in old time by the will of man: but holy men of God spake as they were moved by the Holy Ghost."

WE SHOULD READ THE BIBLE TO RECEIVE KNOWLEDGE OF ETERNAL LIFE!

Eternal life is more important than natural life. Most of us spend much more time and resources on natural life, than eternal life. Our life here will last seventy or eighty years but the life that follows will last forever! Someone said *"forever is a very long time."* If the afterlife is going to last forever, then it should follow, that we allow a little more time and attention to be focused on making sure we are ready for the next step.

One way we do this is through a systematic reading of the Scriptures. The Bible not only reveals the presence of eternal life, but gives careful instructions on how to be ready for that promotion. 1 John 5:13 (NKJV) ***"These things I have written to you who believe in the name of the Son of God, that you may know that you have eternal life, and that you may continue to believe in the name of the Son of God."***

The work of the Holy Spirit is absolutely critical in our walk with God. He begins His work in us by convicting us of our sins. John 16:5-8 (NKJV) ***"But now I go away to Him who sent Me, and none of you asks Me, 'Where are You going?'"***⁶ ***"But because I have said these things to you, sorrow has filled your heart."***⁷ ***"Nevertheless I tell you the truth. It is to your advantage that I go away; for if I do not go away, the Helper will not come to you; but if I depart, I will send Him to you."***⁸ ***"And when He has come, He will convict the world of sin, and of righteousness, and of judgment."***

Once He has convicted us, we are then made aware of the presence of sin within us. As a result, we become knowledgeable of our own mortality, which leads us to consideration of where we are going to spend eternity. This consideration almost always leads to salvation.

Once we are saved, the Holy Spirit, who is our teacher, brings the Word to life as we read it. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** ²

Corinthians 3:6 (NKJV) ***"Who also made us sufficient as ministers of the new covenant, not of the letter but of the Spirit; for the letter kills, but the Spirit gives life."***

When we begin to regularly read and understand the Word of God we become more and more aware of what our eternity is going to be like. Revelation 21:1-7 (NKJV) ***"Now I saw a new heaven and a new earth, for the first heaven and the first earth had passed away. Also there was no more sea."***² ***Then I, John, saw the holy city, New Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, prepared as a bride adorned for her husband."***³ ***And I heard a loud voice from heaven saying,***

“Behold, the tabernacle of God is with men, and He will dwell with them, and they shall be His people. God Himself will be with them and be their God.”⁴ “And God will wipe away every tear from their eyes; there shall be no more death, nor sorrow, nor crying. There shall be no more pain, for the former things have passed away.”⁵ Then He who sat on the throne said, “Behold, I make all things new.” And He said to me, “Write, for these words are true and faithful.”⁶ And He said to me, “It is done! I am the Alpha and the Omega, the Beginning and the End. I will give of the fountain of the water of life freely to him who thirsts.”⁷ “He who overcomes shall inherit all things, and I will be his God and he shall be My son.”

Once we understand our eternity, we make preparations for the eventuality of our journey.

WE SHOULD READ THE BIBLE TO RECEIVE HOPE!

One of the most significant problems in our world today is hopelessness. What is the answer for our society? The Word of God! Listen to what the Word has to say about a hopeless society. Romans 15:4 (NKJV) ***“For whatever things were written before were written for our learning, that we through the patience and comfort of the Scriptures might have hope.”***

It is amazing what a little hope will do! Hope can: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Cause a plan for an abortion to result in the birth of a baby
- Convert suicidal thoughts into a plan for the future
- Turn a criminal into a law-abiding citizen
- Transform a divorce into a loving marriage
- Change a financial flop into an overwhelming success
- Modify stress from a health problem into a testimony

Reading the Bible furnishes the believer with a daily dose of hope! When you visit a doctor for the purpose of acquiring antibiotics to fight an infection he will often give what is referred to a “*bolus dose*” of medication. This is a greater amount than the normal daily dose. The “*bolus dose*” is designed to give your body a jump start of antibiotics in an effort to fight the infection. When the daily doses of hope begin to accumulate, the believer no longer walks in doubt concerning the future, but moves energetically toward it.

The difficulties of life do not tend to sidetrack the believer who receives an adequate amount of hope through daily Bible reading. Hebrews 6:18-19 (NKJV) *"That by two immutable things, in which it is impossible for God to lie, we might have strong consolation, who have fled for refuge to lay hold of the hope set before us. 19 This hope we have as an anchor of the soul, both sure and steadfast, and which enters the Presence behind the veil."*

WE SHOULD READ THE BIBLE TO HAVE IT IMPRINTED ON THE HEART!

The word imprinted means to fix firmly in the mind. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** It can also mean a mark made by a printer or publisher. When a person makes a decision to have a tattoo placed on their body they are not making a temporary choice, they are making a lifelong decision. Many people do such things on the spur of the moment, or even in a state of inebriation. In such cases, the individual oftentimes live to regret such a decision. Once it is done it is almost impossible to correct.

According to the Scripture the reading and study of the Word of God carries with it a process of being imprinted on the heart. Deuteronomy 6:4-8 (KJV) *"Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God is one LORD: 5 And thou shalt love the LORD thy God with all thine heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy might. 6 And these words, which I command thee this day, shall be in thine heart: 7 And thou shalt teach them diligently unto thy children, and shalt talk of them when thou sittest in thine house, and when thou walkest by the way, and when thou liest down, and when thou risest up. 8 And thou shalt bind them for a sign upon thine hand, and they shall be as frontlets between thine eyes."*

Listen to this: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Vs. 6 *"And these words, which I command thee this day, shall be in thine heart."* The inference here is that the Word of God will become imprinted on our hearts in the same way a tattoo is imprinted on a body; a brand is imprinted on an animal; an insignia is imprinted on a product. We should read our Bibles with the intention of the words of this book becoming irreversibly imprinted on our hearts!
- Vs. 7 *"Thou shalt teach them diligently unto thy children."* We should read the Bible with an attention level that would be conducive to taking what we have read and teach it to our children. Remember, there are more ways to teach a lesson than holding a Bible study. Our kids learn mostly by what they see us modeling.

- Vs. 7 "*Thou shalt talk of them when thou sittest in thine house, and when thou walkest by the way, and when thou liest down, and when thou risest up.*" When we read the Word of God on a regular basis it will be surprising how often we discover that it will fit perfectly into a conversation. We should look for opportunities to bring the Word into a conversation.
- Vs. 8 "*thou shalt bind them for a sign upon thine hand.*" The implication here is that the person who stays in the Word will place its contents in a very visible place in their life. This instruction is referring to making a note on our hand, or tying a string around our finger so as not to forget.
- Vs. 8 "*They shall be as frontlets between thine eyes.*" This reference has to do with a farmer or rancher placing blinders on a horse or mule in order to limit the peripheral vision of the beast. (In case it has A.D.D.)

According to this passage of Scripture, when we read and study the Word of God, the effects of the Word will begin to chart out a course for our life. In fact, *the knowledge of the Word is a deterrent to sin!* Psalm 119:11 (NKJV) "*Your word I have hidden in my heart, That I might not sin against You!*"

The imprinting of the Word in our hearts will result in the words of this book being on our lips. Romans 10:8-10 (NKJV) "*But what does it say? “The word is near you, in your mouth and in your heart” (that is, the word of faith which we preach):9 that if you confess with your mouth the Lord Jesus and believe in your heart that God has raised Him from the dead, you will be saved.10 For with the heart one believes unto righteousness, and with the mouth confession is made unto salvation.*"

Illustration: If you have a cup that is completely full of water and someone bumps into you, it is inevitable; you will spill water on that person. When we go out into the world we will spill what we are full of on the world; we should spill the Word of God on them! If one is to be all God intended them to be, a systematic reading of the Word of God will be essential!

WE SHOULD READ THE BIBLE BECAUSE IT FURNISHES A LIGHT!

Darkness is in and of itself a terrible thing. Someone said, "*I am not afraid of the dark, I am afraid of what is in it!*" This illustration bears out the very nature of darkness.

I want to point out the following facts about darkness: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Darkness brings with it the fear of the unknown and unseen

- Darkness is used as a cloak for danger - John 3:19-21 (NKJV) *"... The Light from heaven came into the world, but they loved the darkness more than the Light, for their deeds were evil. 20 They hated the heavenly Light because they wanted to sin in the darkness. They stayed away from that Light for fear their sins would be exposed and they would be punished. 21 But those doing right come gladly to the Light to let everyone see that they are doing what God wants them to."*
- Darkness conceals opportunity
- Darkness impedes progress

Light is the only deterrent to darkness. Psalm 119:130 (NKJV) *"The entrance of Your words gives light; It gives understanding to the simple."*

Light illuminates the desired area of vision and dispels darkness. (Use a flashlight to illustrate this point) Psalm 19:8 (NKJV) *"The statutes of the LORD are right, rejoicing the heart; The commandment of the LORD is pure, enlightening the eyes."* (Stumbling over Jason's toys in the middle of the night)

Because we live in a world that is very dark, we are constantly in need of light! How do we receive the light which we so desperately need? Psalm 119:105 (NKJV) *"Your word is a lamp to my feet And a light to my path."*

2 Peter 1:17-21 (NKJV) *"And we heard this voice which came from heaven when we were with Him on the holy mountain.19 And so we have the prophetic word confirmed, which you do well to heed as a light that shines in a dark place, until the day dawns and the morning star rises in your hearts;"* (Use the Bible as a flashlight)

The light of God is the Word of God! If we want to be enlightened in a dark culture we must be students of the Word of God!

WE SHOULD READ THE BIBLE BECAUSE IT HAS THE POTENTIAL TO PURIFY OUR LIFE!

Every Christian would no doubt readily agree; the will of God is for us to live a life that is pure before the Lord. Before we can live a pure life we must first experience the freedom that only God can provide. John 8:31-32 (NKJV) *"Then Jesus said to those Jews who believed Him, ***'If you abide in My word, you are My disciples indeed.32 'And you shall know the truth, and the truth shall make you free.'***"* What is the truth spoken of in this Scripture? John 17:17 (NKJV) ****'Sanctify them by Your truth. Your word is truth.***"*

We hear a great deal about freedom in our day, but not many people ever experience real freedom. The only people who can experience this freedom are those who know, understand and accept the Word of God!

Freedom has very little to do with where you live or what kind of government you live under. You can live in a democracy and never experience freedom! You can live under a harsh dictatorship and experience freedom! What is the difference? How we relate to His Word!

Once we become free, we must live free, not bringing ourselves back under bondage. Psalm 119:9 (NKJV) ***"How can a young man cleanse his way? By taking heed according to Your word."*** Charles Spurgeon once said, *"If you see a person whose Bible is falling apart, they probably have a life which is not."*

The Word of God purifies our life! John 15:3 (NKJV) ***"You are already clean because of the word which I have spoken to you."*** Ephesians 5:25-26 (NKJV) ***"Husbands, love your wives, just as Christ also loved the church and gave Himself for her, ²⁶ that He might sanctify and cleanse her with the washing of water by the word,"*** The Word of God is to the child of God, what a shower is to the physical body.

I promise you, you cannot pray and read your Bible every day and continue sinning.

WE SHOULD READ THE BIBLE FOR THE PURPOSE OF RECEIVING SEED!

Most of us are aware of the truth that there will not be a harvest unless seed has been sown. Based on this fact, sowing time is at least as important as harvest time. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)**

In our spiritual walk we are instructed to do both; sow and reap! Most of us prefer reaping over sowing! Sowing seed is not nearly as exciting or sensational as harvesting! One thing I learned while pastoring in a farming community is that you never schedule special events during sowing time or harvest time. (Experience of helping to irrigate soy beans & driving a combine...)

If we are to sow seed, we must first receive seed. **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)** What is the seed we are to be sowing? Jesus identifies the seed in the parable of the sower and the seed... Mark 4:1-9, 14-20 (NKJV) ***"And again He began to teach by the sea. And a great multitude was gathered to Him, so that He got into a boat and sat in it on the sea; and the whole multitude was on the***

land facing the sea.² Then He taught them many things by parables, and said to them in His teaching:³ ***"Listen! Behold, a sower went out to sow."***⁴ ***"And it happened, as he sowed, that some seed fell by the wayside; and the birds of the air came and devoured it.***⁵ ***"Some fell on stony ground, where it did not have much earth; and immediately it sprang up because it had no depth of earth.***⁶ ***"But when the sun was up it was scorched, and because it had no root it withered away.***⁷ ***"And some seed fell among thorns; and the thorns grew up and choked it, and it yielded no crop.***⁸ ***"But other seed fell on good ground and yielded a crop that sprang up, increased and produced: some thirtyfold, some sixty, and some a hundred."***... ¹⁴ ***"The sower sows the word."***¹⁵ ***"And these are the ones by the wayside where the word is sown. When they hear, Satan comes immediately and takes away the word that was sown in their hearts.***¹⁶ ***"These likewise are the ones sown on stony ground who, when they hear the word, immediately receive it with gladness;***¹⁷ ***"and they have no root in themselves, and so endure only for a time. Afterward, when tribulation or persecution arises for the word's sake, immediately they stumble.***¹⁸ ***"Now these are the ones sown among thorns; they are the ones who hear the word,***¹⁹ ***"and the cares of this world, the deceitfulness of riches, and the desires for other things entering in choke the word, and it becomes unfruitful.***²⁰ ***"But these are the ones sown on good ground, those who hear the word, accept it, and bear fruit: some thirtyfold, some sixty, and some a hundred."***

We cannot very well sow seed without first receiving seed. We receive seed by becoming a student of the Word of God: **(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- [Daily Bible reading](#)
- [Studying the Word](#)
- [Attending a discipleship class](#) which is based on the Word of God
- [Submitting to a Pastor](#) who preaches the Word

Once we have received the Word of God we should make sure our attitude in sowing is right! Psalm 126:6 (NKJV) ***"He who continually goes forth weeping, Bearing seed for sowing, Shall doubtless come again with rejoicing, Bringing his sheaves with him."***

When a farmer sows seed he is limited by the amount of [land](#) he has set aside for sowing and the amount of [seed](#) he possesses. The believer experiences the exact same [limitations](#). 2 Corinthians 9:8-10 (LB) ***"For God, who gives seed to the farmer to plant, and later on good crops to harvest and eat, will give you more***

and more seed to plant and will make it grow so that you can give away more and more fruit from your harvest. " We must continually feed on the Word because it is seed and we are planters who need something to sow!

CONCLUSION:

Will you make a commitment to reading your Bible each day? **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE END OF SESSION)**

(Encourage everyone to purchase a one year Bible)

One cannot walk a consistent Christian walk without systematically referring to the roadmap for victorious living: the Bible!

FACILITATOR'S QUESTIONS:

- 1) Is the Bible relevant in today's culture?
- 2) How often should one read the Bible?
- 3) Why is reading the Bible so important in the life of the believer?
- 4) What proof does the Bible offer as to its authenticity?
- 5) What language was the Old Testament written in?
- 6) What language was the New Testament written in?

NEXTSTEPS 101
FOLLOWING JESUS IN WATER BAPTISM
(4 of 8)

BLUE – POWER POINT PRESENTATION

BROWN – INSTRUCTIONS TO TECHNICIAN

TEXT: [Mark 1:9-11](#) (NKJV) *“It came to pass in those days that Jesus came from Nazareth of Galilee, and was baptized by John in the Jordan. ¹⁰And immediately, coming up from the water, He saw the heavens parting and the Spirit descending upon Him like a dove. ¹¹Then a voice came from heaven, “You are My beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased.”*

[Mark 16:15-16](#) (NKJV) *“He said to them, **“Go into all the world and preach the gospel to every creature. ¹⁶“He who believes and is baptized will be saved; but he who does not believe will be condemned.”***

[Colossians 2:12](#) (NKJV) *“Buried with Him in baptism, in which you also were raised with Him through faith in the working of God, who raised Him from the dead.”*

[Romans 6:3-11](#) (NKJV) *“Do you not know that as many of us as were baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into His death? ⁴Therefore we were buried with Him through baptism into death, that just as Christ was raised from the dead by the glory of the Father, even so we also should walk in newness of life. ⁵For if we have been united together in the likeness of His death, certainly we also shall be in the likeness of His resurrection, ⁶knowing this, that our old man was crucified with Him, that the body of sin might be done away with, that we should no longer be slaves of sin. ⁷For he who has died has been freed from sin. ⁸Now if we died with Christ, we believe that we shall also live with Him, ⁹knowing that Christ, having been raised from the dead, dies no more. Death no longer has dominion over Him. ¹⁰For the death that He died, He died to sin once for all; but the life that He lives, He lives to God. ¹¹Likewise you also, reckon yourselves to be dead indeed to sin, but alive to God in Christ Jesus our Lord.”*

INTRO: One of the great fundamentals of the Protestant faith is the belief in the ordinances of the church. [Most evangelical Christians embrace two ordinances:](#)
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- [Holy Communion](#)

- [Water Baptism](#)

In this lesson we are going to be examining the ordinance of water baptism and why it is so very crucial for a Christian to take this very important step. Before we get into the reasons for water baptism I want to make [several facts about water baptism](#) abundantly clear:

- Baptism is an act [reserved](#) for those who have accepted the Lord Jesus as savior - Baptism is meaningless unless it is the act of one who has accepted the Lord Jesus Christ as his personal Savior.
- Baptism is an act of [obedience](#), not an act of [regeneration](#) - Mark 16:15-16 (NKJV) ***“He said to them, “Go into all the world and preach the gospel to every creature.”*** ¹⁶***“He who believes and is baptized will be saved; but he who does not believe will be condemned.”*** Acts 16:30-33 (NKJV) ***“He (The jailer) brought them out and said, “Sirs, what must I do to be saved?”*** ³¹***“So they said, “Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ, and you will be saved, you and your household.”*** ³²***“Then they spoke the word of the Lord to him and to all who were in his house.”*** ³³***“And he took them the same hour of the night and washed their stripes. And immediately he and all his family were baptized.”*** The use of water in this ordinance suggests the cleansing action of regeneration on the soul. Some passages almost sound as though baptism itself saves. Acts 2:38 (NKJV) ***“Then Peter said to them, “Repent, and let every one of you be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins; and you shall receive the gift of the Holy Spirit.”*** Mark 16:16 (NKJV) ***“He who believes and is baptized will be saved; but he who does not believe will be condemned.”*** Titus 3:4-7 (NKJV) ***“When the kindness and the love of God our Savior toward man appeared, ⁵not by works of righteousness which we have done, but according to His mercy He saved us, through the washing of regeneration and renewing of the Holy Spirit, ⁶whom He poured out on us abundantly through Jesus Christ our Savior, ⁷that having been justified by His grace we should become heirs according to the hope of eternal life.”*** We know from the example of the thief on the cross that one may be saved even though he has not had opportunity in life to be baptized. Luke 23:39-43 (NKJV) ***“Then one of the criminals who were hanged blasphemed Him, saying, “If You are the Christ, save Yourself and us.”*** ⁴⁰***“But the other, answering, rebuked him, saying, “Do you not even fear God, seeing you are under the same condemnation?”*** ⁴¹***“And we indeed justly, for we receive the due reward of our deeds; but this Man has done nothing wrong.”*** ⁴²***“Then he said to Jesus, “Lord, remember me when You come into Your kingdom.”*** ⁴³***“And Jesus said to him, “Assuredly, I say to you, today you will be with Me in Paradise.”***

- Baptism should occur as soon after conversion as possible - Acts 8:36-38 (NKJV) *“As they went down the road, they came to some water. And the eunuch said, “See, here is water. What hinders me from being baptized?” ³⁷Then Philip said, “If you believe with all your heart, you may.” And he answered and said, “I believe that Jesus Christ is the Son of God.” ³⁸So he commanded the chariot to stand still. And both Philip and the eunuch went down into the water, and he baptized him.”*
- Baptism is not optional for those who desire to be obedient disciples - Water baptism as an ordinance of Christ signifies entrance into the visible Church, just as conversion secured entrance into the invisible Church. Because water baptism is a gateway into identification with the church Jesus died to build, obedience to this ordinance is not optional!
- Baptism should be performed by immersion - The word translated baptize in the New Testament means to dip, to immerse, to plunge, to drench, to sink, to overwhelm. Immersion in water is intended to speak of a much more significant condition of the heart; the heart and spirit of the person being overwhelmed by the presence and life of Jesus! Mark 1:9-11 (NKJV) *“It came to pass in those days that Jesus came from Nazareth of Galilee, and was baptized by John in the Jordan. ¹⁰And immediately, coming up from the water, He saw the heavens parting and the Spirit descending upon Him like a dove. ¹¹Then a voice came from heaven, “You are My beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased.””* When we baptize we submerge the candidate in water. The fundamental meaning of baptism is immersion into the nature of God. This experience is first spiritual and takes place at conversion. It is next outward and physical, taking place when a minister momentarily submerges a believer under the water. The physical act is thus a picture of the spiritual act.
- The command for baptism is in the name of Jesus - Acts 2:38 (NKJV) *“Then Peter said to them, “Repent, and let every one of you be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins; and you shall receive the gift of the Holy Spirit.”*
- The mode of baptism is in the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit - Matthew 28:16-20 (NKJV) *“Then the eleven disciples went away into Galilee, to the mountain which Jesus had appointed for them. ¹⁷When they saw Him, they worshiped Him; but some doubted. ¹⁸And Jesus came and spoke to them, saying, “All authority has been given to Me in heaven and on earth. ¹⁹“Go therefore and make disciples of all the nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, ²⁰“teaching them to observe all things that I have commanded you;”*

and lo, I am with you always, even to the end of the age.” Amen.”

WE SHOULD BE BAPTIZED BECAUSE JESUS OUR GREAT EXAMPLE WAS BAPTIZED!

Mark 1:9-11 (NKJV) *“It came to pass in those days that Jesus came from Nazareth of Galilee, and was baptized by John in the Jordan. ¹⁰And immediately, coming up from the water, He saw the heavens parting and the Spirit descending upon Him like a dove. ¹¹Then a voice came from heaven, “You are My beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased.”* One of the great indisputable facts of the Bible is the baptism of Jesus. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** Jesus’ cousin, John the Baptist, was a very popular religious figure who preached in the countryside a message of repentance. John not only demanded that his followers turn from unholy living but he required that they make a public declaration of their change-of-ways by being baptized in water.

John’s message was not very popular in religious circles, in fact he was martyred, and his baptism was even more unpopular! It was against this backdrop that Jesus approaches his cousin to baptize Him in water. Matthew 3:13-15 (NKJV) *“Then Jesus came from Galilee to John at the Jordan to be baptized by him. ¹⁴And John tried to prevent Him, saying, “I need to be baptized by You, and are You coming to me?” ¹⁵But Jesus answered and said to him, “**Permit it to be so now, for thus it is fitting for us to fulfill all righteousness.**” Then he allowed Him.”* John actually made an attempt to discourage Jesus from being baptized because he did not feel worthy to be the one who performed this task with Jesus. He further states that he needed Jesus to baptize him!

If Jesus our great example felt it necessary to be baptized in water what makes us think doing such a thing is unnecessary for us? We should be baptized because Jesus set the example for us!

WE SHOULD BE BAPTIZED BECAUSE THE APOSTLES SET THE EXAMPLE FOR US!

A short list of those who performed baptisms in Scripture would include:

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Jesus and His disciples baptized individuals during Jesus’ earthly ministry - John 3:22 (NKJV) *“After these things Jesus and His disciples came into the land of Judea, and there He remained with them and baptized.”* John 4:1-3 (NKJV) *“When the Lord knew that the Pharisees had heard that Jesus made and baptized more disciples than John ²(though Jesus Himself*

did not baptize, but His disciples), ³He left Judea and departed again to Galilee.”

- Peter baptized [3,000](#) on the Day of Pentecost - Acts 2:38-42 (NKJV) *“Then Peter said to them, “Repent, and let every one of you be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins; and you shall receive the gift of the Holy Spirit.”* ³⁹*“For the promise is to you and to your children, and to all who are afar off, as many as the Lord our God will call.”* ⁴⁰*And with many other words he testified and exhorted them, saying, “Be saved from this perverse generation.”* ⁴¹*Then those who gladly received his word were baptized; and that day about three thousand souls were added to them.* ⁴²*And they continued steadfastly in the apostles’ doctrine and fellowship, in the breaking of bread, and in prayers.”*
- Philip baptized believers at [Samaria](#) - Acts 8:12-13 (NKJV) *“When they believed Philip as he preached the things concerning the kingdom of God and the name of Jesus Christ, both men and women were baptized.* ¹³*Then Simon himself also believed; and when he was baptized he continued with Philip, and was amazed, seeing the miracles and signs which were done.”*
- Philip baptized the Ethiopian eunuch in [Gaza](#) - Acts 8:36-38 (NKJV) *“As they went down the road, they came to some water. And the eunuch said, “See, here is water. What hinders me from being baptized?”* ³⁷*Then Philip said, “If you believe with all your heart, you may.” And he answered and said, “I believe that Jesus Christ is the Son of God.”* ³⁸*So he commanded the chariot to stand still. And both Philip and the eunuch went down into the water, and he baptized him.”*
- Paul was baptized at [Damascus](#) - Acts 9:18 (NKJV) *“Immediately there fell from his eyes something like scales, and he received his sight at once; and he arose and was baptized.”*
- Peter baptized Gentiles in the house of [Cornelius](#) - Acts 10: 44-48 (NKJV) *“While Peter was still speaking these words, the Holy Spirit fell upon all those who heard the word.”* ⁴⁵*And those of the circumcision who believed were astonished, as many as came with Peter, because the gift of the Holy Spirit had been poured out on the Gentiles also.* ⁴⁶*For they heard them speak with tongues and magnify God. Then Peter answered,* ⁴⁷*“Can anyone forbid water, that these should not be baptized who have received the Holy Spirit just as we have?”* ⁴⁸*And he commanded them to be baptized in the name of the Lord.”*
- Paul baptized [Lydia](#) and her family - Acts 16:14-15 (NKJV) *“A certain woman named Lydia heard us. She was a seller of purple from the city of Thyatira, who worshiped God. The Lord opened her heart to heed the*

things spoken by Paul. ¹⁵And when she and her household were baptized, she begged us, saying, “If you have judged me to be faithful to the Lord, come to my house and stay.” So she persuaded us.”

- Paul baptized the Philippian jailer and his family - Acts 16:30-33 (NKJV) “He (The jailer) brought them out and said, “Sirs, what must I do to be saved?” ³¹So they said, “Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ, and you will be saved, you and your household.” ³²Then they spoke the word of the Lord to him and to all who were in his house. ³³And he took them the same hour of the night and washed their stripes. And immediately he and all his family were baptized.”
- Paul baptized many at Corinth - Acts 18:8 (NKJV) “Then Crispus, the ruler of the synagogue, believed on the Lord with all his household. And many of the Corinthians, hearing, believed and were baptized.”
- Paul baptized twelve people at Ephesus - Acts 19:1-7 (NKJV) “While Apollos was at Corinth, that Paul, having passed through the upper regions, came to Ephesus. And finding some disciples ²he said to them, “Did you receive the Holy Spirit when you believed?” So they said to him, “We have not so much as heard whether there is a Holy Spirit.” ³And he said to them, “Into what then were you baptized?” So they said, “Into John’s baptism.” ⁴Then Paul said, “John indeed baptized with a baptism of repentance, saying to the people that they should believe on Him who would come after him, that is, on Christ Jesus.” ⁵When they heard this, they were baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus. ⁶And when Paul had laid hands on them, the Holy Spirit came upon them, and they spoke with tongues and prophesied. ⁷Now the men were about twelve in all.”

WE SHOULD BE BAPTIZED BECAUSE WE HAVE BEEN COMMANDED TO DO SO!

(PLACE SCRIPTURE REFERENCE AND SCRIPTURE ON THE SCREEN AT THE SAME TIME AND LEAVE IT THERE UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)

Acts 2:38-42 (NKJV) “Then Peter said to them, “Repent, and let every one of you be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins; and you shall receive the gift of the Holy Spirit.” ³⁹“For the promise is to you and to your children, and to all who are afar off, as many as the Lord our God will call.” ⁴⁰And with many other words he testified and exhorted them, saying, “Be saved from this perverse generation.” ⁴¹Then those who gladly received his word were baptized; and that day about three thousand souls were added to them.

⁴²And they continued steadfastly in the apostles’ doctrine and fellowship, in the breaking of bread, and in prayers.” Acts 10: 44-48 (NKJV) “While Peter was still speaking these words, the Holy Spirit fell upon all those who heard the word.

⁴⁵*And those of the circumcision who believed were astonished, as many as came with Peter, because the gift of the Holy Spirit had been poured out on the Gentiles also.* ⁴⁶*For they heard them speak with tongues and magnify God. Then Peter answered,* ⁴⁷*“Can anyone forbid water, that these should not be baptized who have received the Holy Spirit just as we have?”* ⁴⁸*And he commanded them to be baptized in the name of the Lord.”*

WE SHOULD BE BAPTIZED BECAUSE DOING SO SIGNIFIES WE ARE RENOUNCING OUR OLD LIFE!

In the BC (Before Christ) life, most of us were identified by our behavior! We should always remember our name and our conduct are always synonymous.

(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE) When our name was mentioned those who knew us, and those who knew about us, immediately conjured up images based on our past track record. Once we come to know Christ our life undergoes a transformation and we are no longer the same! 2 Corinthians 5:17 (KJV) *“If any man be in Christ, he is a new creature: old things are passed away; behold, all things are become new.”* The conversion experience not only changes us but we are no longer free to behave in the same way we have become accustomed to behaving.

The act of going down into the baptismal pool is a public statement that we are leaving the old life with all its bondages and encumbrances behind! What a wonderful declaration! Water baptism is a bold testimonial that the old life is now a thing of the past! **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** Once we renounce the old life we must then reject its conduct as a possible course of action in the future!

We should be baptized as an act of rejecting the old life!

WE SHOULD BE BAPTIZED BECAUSE DOING SO SIGNIFIES OUR SIN NATURE HAS BEEN DEALT WITH!

The act of being baptized in a watery grave signifies the old sin nature is being dealt with in a very radical way! The only way to deal with sin and live above its influence is to become radical with it. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** Galatians 2:20 (NKJV) *“I have been crucified with Christ; it is no longer I who live, but Christ lives in me; and the life which I now live in the flesh I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave Himself for me.”*

The only way to deal with the sin nature is to kill it and bury it; otherwise we will

allow it to be revived in our lives. Romans 7:18-23 (NKJV) ***"I know that in me (that is, in my flesh) nothing good dwells; for to will is present with me, but how to perform what is good I do not find. ¹⁹For the good that I will to do, I do not do; but the evil I will not to do, that I practice. ²⁰Now if I do what I will not to do, it is no longer I who do it, but sin that dwells in me. ²¹I find then a law, that evil is present with me, the one who wills to do good. ²²For I delight in the law of God according to the inward man. ²³But I see another law in my members, warring against the law of my mind, and bringing me into captivity to the law of sin which is in my members."***

The early Christians practiced actual submersion to symbolize the fact that the believer had died to sin. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** (Story of elderly woman who heard the Pastor say "You must kill the old man." She said, "I can't kill him, I love him too much!")

The very act of water baptism is radical, and the way we must deal with our sin nature is radical. We should be baptized in water as a radical act of dealing with the sinful nature!

WE SHOULD BE BAPTIZED BECAUSE DOING SO SIGNIFIES WE ARE GOING TO LIVE DIFFERENTLY IN THE FUTURE!

When a person is baptized in water, the death, burial and resurrection of Jesus is represented: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- The act of going into the water represents the death of Jesus
- The act of being immersed in water represents the burial of Jesus
- The act of being raised up out of the water represents the resurrection of Jesus

Not only does the act of being raised out of water represent the resurrection of Jesus, it also declares we are going to live overcoming lives through the resurrection power which Jesus provides. We cannot live this life by our own volition; we must have the power of God operating in us, and through us.

(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE) Romans 8:7-9 (NKJV) ***"The carnal mind is enmity against God: for it is not subject to the law of God, neither indeed can be. ⁸So then they that are in the flesh cannot please God. ⁹But ye are not in the flesh, but in the Spirit, if so be that the Spirit of God dwell in you. Now if any man have not the Spirit of Christ, he is none of his."***

We should be baptized in water because doing so signals to us, our friends, the world, and the devil that our conduct will be different in the future!

CONCLUSION:

Any believer who wishes to be obedient to what Jesus has commanded us to do will follow Him in water baptism as soon as possible. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE END OF THE SESSION)** To not be willing to follow through on this very important ordinance is to become a disobedient son or daughter. Are you willing to follow the Lord in water baptism?

(Distribute application forms for water baptism... Announce next water baptism service)

FACILITATOR'S QUESTIONS:

- 1) Who should be baptized?
- 2) How should one be baptized?
- 3) When should one be baptized?
- 4) Should infants be baptized?
- 5) Is baptism necessary for salvation?
- 6) Why would one not want to be baptized?

NEXTSTEPS 101

RECEIVING THE HOLY SPIRIT

(5 of 8)

BLUE – POWER POINT PRESENTATION

BROWN – INSTRUCTIONS TO TECHNICIAN

TEXT: Acts 2:1-4 (NKJV) *"When the Day of Pentecost had fully come, they were all with one accord in one place.² And suddenly there came a sound from heaven, as of a rushing mighty wind, and it filled the whole house where they were sitting.³ Then there appeared to them divided tongues, as of fire, and one sat upon each of them.⁴ And they were all filled with the Holy Spirit and began to speak with other tongues, as the Spirit gave them utterance."*

Acts 2:38-40 (NKJV) *"Then Peter said to them, "Repent, and let every one of you be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins; and you shall receive the gift of the Holy Spirit.³⁹ "For the promise is to you and to your children, and to all who are afar off, as many as the Lord our God will call."*

Ephesians 5:15-20 (KJV) *"See then that ye walk circumspectly, not as fools, but as wise, ¹⁶ Redeeming the time, because the days are evil. ¹⁷ Wherefore be ye not unwise, but understanding what the will of the Lord is. ¹⁸ And be not drunk with wine, wherein is excess; but be filled with the Spirit; ¹⁹ Speaking to yourselves in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, singing and making melody in your heart to the Lord; ²⁰ Giving thanks always for all things unto God and the Father in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ."*

INTRO: Most people, who call themselves Christian, believe in the person of the Holy Spirit, at least in some limited dimension. The extent of these beliefs has made for many interesting conversations as well as quite a large number of heated religious debates.

Following conversion, those who have received the infilling of the Holy Spirit as a second definite work of grace are widely known as Pentecostal or Charismatic.

In September 2004, at the Pentecostal World Conference in Seoul, South Korea, Christianity Today reported that Pentecostals worldwide numbered at least 450,000,000. It is believed that in some nations of the earth as much as 25% of the population is Pentecostal. (Pentecostal revivals in Argentina; Brazil; and Chile)

The Assemblies of God fellowship was formed in Hot Springs, AR in 1914 with a group of 300. Less than a hundred years later the number of adherents is more than 53,000,000 worldwide.

To begin with, I want to point out what I believe to be several general Scriptural facts concerning the person of the Holy Spirit: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- The Holy Spirit is the third person of the Holy trinity
- The Holy Spirit works in unity with the Father and the Son
- The Holy Spirit is the power behind the implementation of God's purpose in the earth

In order to fully understand the subject matter I want to attempt to answer the following questions: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Is the baptism in the Holy Spirit for all believers? Acts 2:38-40 (NKJV)
"Then Peter said to them, "Repent, and let every one of you be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins; and you shall receive the gift of the Holy Spirit."³⁹ "For the promise is to you and to your children, and to all who are afar off, as many as the Lord our God will call."
- Does a believer receive the Holy Spirit at conversion? Acts 19:1-7 (NKJV)
"And it happened, while Apollos was at Corinth, that Paul, having passed through the upper regions, came to Ephesus. And finding some disciples² he said to them, "Did you receive the Holy Spirit when you believed?" So they said to him, "We have not so much as heard whether there is a Holy Spirit."³ And he said to them, "Into what then were you baptized?" So they said, "Into John's baptism."⁴ Then Paul said, "John indeed baptized with a baptism of repentance, saying to the people that they should believe on Him who would come after him, that is, on Christ Jesus."⁵ When they heard this, they were baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus.⁶ And when Paul had laid hands on them, the Holy Spirit came upon them, and they spoke with tongues and prophesied.⁷ Now the men were about twelve in all." All believers receive the seal of the Holy Spirit at conversion. The baptism in the Holy Spirit is a second work of grace, subsequent to the work of salvation.
- To receive the Holy Spirit, is it necessary to speak in tongues? To adequately answer this question, I want us to look at each time groups of people or individuals received the Holy Spirit in the book of Acts: **(1)** Acts 2:1-4 (KJV) *"And when the day of Pentecost was fully come, they were all*

with one accord in one place. 2 And suddenly there came a sound from heaven as of a rushing mighty wind, and it filled all the house where they were sitting. 3 And there appeared unto them cloven tongues like as of fire, and it sat upon each of them. 4 And they were all filled with the Holy Ghost, and began to speak with other tongues, as the Spirit gave them utterance." We must conclude that in this initial outpouring, each of the 120 did in fact speak in tongues. (2) Acts 8:14-18 (KJV) *"Now when the apostles which were at Jerusalem heard that Samaria had received the word of God, they sent unto them Peter and John: 15 Who, when they were come down, prayed for them, that they might receive the Holy Ghost: 16 (For as yet he was fallen upon none of them: only they were baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus.) 17 Then laid they their hands on them, and they received the Holy Ghost. 18 And when Simon saw that through laying on of the apostles' hands the Holy Ghost was given, he offered them money."* This Scripture does not say that they spoke in tongues, but there was some kind of visible sign of the outpouring of the Spirit, because even Simon recognized what had happened. (3) Acts 9:17-18 (KJV) *"And Ananias went his way, and entered into the house; and putting his hands on him said, Brother Saul, the Lord, even Jesus, that appeared unto thee in the way as thou camest, hath sent me, that thou mightest receive thy sight, and be filled with the Holy Ghost. 18 And immediately there fell from his eyes as it had been scales: and he received sight forthwith, and arose, and was baptized."* This outpouring of the Spirit upon Saul, who would later become Paul, does not reference the fact that he spoke in tongues, but listen to what Paul says at a later time. 1 Corinthians 14:18 (NKJV) *"I thank my God I speak with tongues more than you all."* (4) Acts 10:44-46 (NKJV) *"While Peter was still speaking these words, the Holy Spirit fell upon all those who heard the word. 45 And those of the circumcision who believed were astonished, as many as came with Peter, because the gift of the Holy Spirit had been poured out on the Gentiles also. 46 For they heard them speak with tongues and magnify God."* This is the account of the outpouring of the Holy Spirit upon the house of Cornelius, who was a Gentile. The Gentiles did speak in tongues when they were filled with the Spirit. (5) Acts 19:1-6 (NKJV) *"And it happened, while Apollos was at Corinth, that Paul, having passed through the upper regions, came to Ephesus. And finding some disciples 2 he said to them, "Did you receive the Holy Spirit when you believed?" So they said to him, "We have not so much as heard whether there is a Holy Spirit." 3 And he said to them, "Into what then were you baptized?" So they said, "Into John's baptism." 4 Then Paul said, "John indeed baptized with a baptism*

of repentance, saying to the people that they should believe on Him who would come after him, that is, on Christ Jesus.”⁵ When they heard this, they were baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus.⁶ And when Paul had laid hands on them, the Holy Spirit came upon them, and they spoke with tongues and prophesied.”

- Why was tongues chosen as the initial physical evidence of Holy Spirit Baptism? The tongue is the most unruly member of the body. James 3:6-8 (NKJV) *"And the tongue is a fire, a world of iniquity. The tongue is so set among our members that it defiles the whole body, and sets on fire the course of nature; and it is set on fire by hell.⁷ For every kind of beast and bird, of reptile and creature of the sea, is tamed and has been tamed by mankind.⁸ But no man can tame the tongue. It is an unruly evil, full of deadly poison."*

Before we decide to write the Holy Spirit off as unimportant or insignificant we should consider the words of Jesus as it relates to the importance of the Holy Spirit. John 16:7 (KJV) *"Nevertheless I tell you the truth; It is expedient for you that I go away: for if I go not away, the Comforter will not come unto you; but if I depart, I will send him unto you."*

In this Scripture, Jesus is stressing to His disciples the necessity of His departure. As long as He lived in a flesh and blood body He could only be in one place at a time. He is attempting to explain to them that the reason it was so necessary for Him to go to the Father was so that the Holy Spirit would come and live in each believer, thus empowering each believer to carry on the work of Christ in the world.

If Jesus thought it necessary to depart so that the Holy Spirit could indwell and empower believers, where do we get off promoting the Holy Spirit as optional equipment?

I want us to look at seven Scriptural reasons for being filled with the Spirit...

WE SHOULD RECEIVE THE HOLY SPIRIT BECAUSE WE HAVE BEEN COMMANDED TO DO SO!

No doubt, every believer would agree that to disobey one of the Ten Commandments would be to sin. What I am about to say will more than likely be viewed as a very narrow interpretation of Scripture. I believe all disobedience is sin. We are commanded in Scripture to be filled with the Spirit. Paul said to the Ephesians *"And be not drunk with wine, wherein is excess; but be filled with the Spirit;"* (Eph. 5:18)

Listen to what Jesus has to say on the subject! [Luke 24:49](#) (NKJV) ***“Behold, I send the Promise of My Father upon you; but tarry in the city of Jerusalem until you are endued with power from on high.”*** Jesus deemed the infilling of the Holy Spirit so significant in the lives of the first century Apostles that he demanded they place their lives and schedules on hold to join into a ten-day prayer meeting! The people Jesus is speaking to here were busy people! They were not unemployed and sitting around hoping someone would assign them a responsibility for ten days and nights!

At the conclusion of this ten-day prayer meeting they received the infilling of the Holy Spirit! [Acts 2:1-4](#) (NKJV) ***“And when the day of Pentecost was fully come, they were all with one accord in one place. 2 And suddenly there came a sound from heaven as of a rushing mighty wind, and it filled all the house where they were sitting. 3 And there appeared unto them cloven tongues like as of fire, and it sat upon each of them. 4 And they were all filled with the Holy Ghost, and began to speak with other tongues, as the Spirit gave them utterance.”***

The reason Jesus commanded these busy people to spend ten days in a prayer meeting is because he knew they were going to need the power the Holy Spirit could furnish! He looked down the road ahead of them to a day when they would need power for life and service! **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)**

The same thing applies to all of us twenty-one centuries later! Someone asked, *“Must I be filled with the Holy Spirit to go to Heaven?”* My answer, *“I would not want to go to the post office without the Holy Spirit!”*

God never commands us to do anything simply for the spiritual exercise! When He gives us a command there are always a host of reasons behind His commands!

We should receive the Holy Spirit because we have been commanded to do so!

WE SHOULD RECEIVE THE HOLY SPIRIT BECAUSE HE HAS BEEN APPOINTED AS OUR TEACHER!

In our lifetime all of us have had many teachers. Very few of us recall specific profound lessons our teachers taught us but we do remember the lessons they taught us through the relationships they built with us!

An evangelist friend and I graduated from the same high school. A few years ago I was serving as the District Christian Education Director for the Assemblies of God in Arkansas. One day this evangelist friend and I were passing through the town

where we graduated, so we decided to stop in for a visit and talk to a few teachers we had not seen since our high school days. As we were visiting with our former English teacher she asked what we were doing for a living, when we told her she hesitated for a minute and said, *"That is a little frightening!"*

Teachers oftentimes become mentors to their students! Jesus tells us that by design, the Holy Spirit is to become the instructor of each believer! John 14:26 (NKJV) ***"But the Helper, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in My name, He will teach you all things, and bring to your remembrance all things that I said to you."***

When we receive the infilling of the Holy Spirit we receive a heightened awareness of the will of God, as well as a heightened sensitivity to the voice of the Holy Spirit. When a person has received the infilling of the Holy Spirit, this teacher opens the Word of God as never before! The truths of God's Word seem to come alive to the believer! Because this teacher lives within us, He is able to bring back to our remembrance the Word of God at a moment's notice! This teacher speaks to us from within, when we are doing right, and when we are doing wrong! It's like having an English teacher whispering in our ears 24/7.

The closer the relationship we develop with the teacher, the more we are capable of learning! It is not the responsibility of the mentor to make time for the mentee; it is the responsibility of the mentee to carve out time to spend at the feet of the mentor! The more shallow the relationships with the teacher, the less we are capable of learning! We are as close to Him as we want to be!

We should receive the Holy Spirit to receive Godly instruction!

WE SHOULD RECEIVE THE HOLY SPIRIT BECAUSE HE HAS BEEN APPOINTED AS OUR GUIDE!

A guide is defined as one who knows the way, usually because they have already been there. If I am going to follow a guide, I want to know that they know what they are doing and where they are going! (My experience in a helicopter at Mt. Rushmore)

There is a terrific difference between a pioneer and a guide. A pioneer blazes a trail in hopes of developing a path for others to follow. A guide is one who already knows the way and leads those who are less knowledgeable along the path.

(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE) John 16:12-15 (NKJV) ***"I still have many things to say to you, but you cannot bear them now.¹³ "However,***

when He, the Spirit of truth, has come, He will guide you into all truth; for He will not speak on His own authority, but whatever He hears He will speak; and He will tell you things to come.¹⁴ "He will glorify Me, for He will take of what is Mine and declare it to you.¹⁵ "All things that the Father has are Mine. Therefore I said that He will take of Mine and declare it to you. "

The work of the Holy Spirit in the life of the believer is that of revelation. He has no agenda of His own; He is simply a guide who discovers what the Father desires in our lives and reveals the path of travel to each believer.

A portion of the work of the Holy Spirit consists of revealing the will of God for ministry to each believer! Acts 13:2-4 (NKJV) "*As they ministered to the Lord and fasted, the Holy Spirit said, "Now separate to Me Barnabas and Saul for the work to which I have called them."*³ Then, having fasted and prayed, and laid hands on them, they sent them away. 4 So, being sent out by the Holy Spirit, they went down to Seleucia, and from there they sailed to Cyprus."

There is an old song that says "*The Lord knows the way through the wilderness, all I have to do is follow.*" If the Lord knows the way, which He does; He then reveals it to the Holy Spirit; who in turn reveals it to the believer. If the Holy Spirit is our guide we must follow His instructions implicitly!

We should receive the Holy Spirit because He can reveal the path of life!

WE SHOULD RECEIVE THE HOLY SPIRIT BECAUSE HE EMPOWERS US FOR SERVICE!

It is my opinion that all who have received Jesus as Lord and Savior will have a desire to serve Him and others.

In the Old Testament the priest would anoint his right ear, right thumb and right great toe. This symbolized: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Having the mind of Christ
- Doing the work of Christ
- Walking the walk of Christ

The three things every believer must do in order to please God is to: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Have the mind of Christ
- Do the work of Christ
- Walk the walk of Christ

Serving strictly from duty or obligation runs a little thin pretty quick. If we are to serve effectively over the long haul of our Christian lives we must operate in the power of the Spirit, rather than functioning within our own abilities or giftedness! Acts 1:8 (NKJV) **"But you shall receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you; and you shall be witnesses to Me in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth."**

Some people think they can do the work of God through their own ability! This is impossible over the long haul and is fatalistic thinking! **Jesus needed the empowerment of the Holy Spirit to do what He was able to do!** Acts 10:38 (NKJV) **"How God anointed Jesus of Nazareth with the Holy Spirit and with power, who went about doing good and healing all who were oppressed by the devil, for God was with Him."** The Apostle Paul was aware of his need for the anointing and empowerment of the **Holy Spirit** to do the work of God. 2 Corinthians 3:2-6 (NKJV) **"You are our epistle written in our hearts, known and read by all men;3 clearly you are an epistle of Christ, ministered by us, written not with ink but by the Spirit of the living God, not on tablets of stone but on tablets of flesh, that is, of the heart. 4 And we have such trust through Christ toward God.5 Not that we are sufficient of ourselves to think of anything as being from ourselves, but our sufficiency is from God,6 who also made us sufficient as ministers of the new covenant, not of the letter but of the Spirit; for the letter kills, but the Spirit gives life."** If Jesus and Paul needed the empowerment of the Holy Spirit, we will surely need His help!

We should receive the Holy Spirit to be empowered for service!

WE SHOULD RECEIVE THE HOLY SPIRIT BECAUSE HE WILL PRAY THROUGH US WHEN WE DO NOT KNOW WHAT TO PRAY FOR!

As we have already learned, the prayer life of each believer is vital to his or her survival and success as a Christian. **One of the works of the Holy Spirit in the life of the believer is to enhance and make more effective his or her prayer life.**

Romans 8:26-27 (NKJV) **"Likewise the Spirit also helps in our weaknesses. For we do not know what we should pray for as we ought, but the Spirit Himself makes intercession for us with groanings which cannot be uttered.27 Now He who searches the hearts knows what the mind of the Spirit is, because He makes intercession for the saints according to the will of God."**

Think of this: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- When we do not know what to pray for, the Holy Spirit knows exactly what to pray for
- When we do not know how to pray because we do not know what the will of the Father is, the Holy Spirit is never in question about the will of God
- When we have exhausted our vocabulary, the Spirit has not exhausted His

The Holy Spirit anoints us to pray in two very distinct ways: 1 Corinthians 14:15 (NKJV) *"I will pray with the spirit, and I will also pray with the understanding. I will sing with the spirit, and I will also sing with the understanding."* **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- In the Spirit - In tongues!
- In the Spirit - In our native language! (Being asked to pray in the Arkansas Governor's mansion) (Praying over a house where some strange activity had been going on)

I am sure all of us have felt at times that our prayer life is somewhat deficient and inadequate. The Holy Spirit has been appointed to be our helper in prayer. What we lack, He makes up for. The most effective praying is Holy Spirit anointed praying!

We should receive the Holy Spirit and allow Him to pray through us!

WE SHOULD RECEIVE THE HOLY SPIRIT BECAUSE HE IS TO BE OUR COMFORTER!

John 15:26 (KJV) *"But when the Comforter is come, whom I will send unto you from the Father, even the Spirit of truth, which proceedeth from the Father, he shall testify of me:"*

On numerous occasions in the Bible, the Holy Spirit is referred to as the comforter. Because of the times we are living in, when we use the word comforter, all kinds of images begin to manifest themselves, most of which do not lend themselves to a true assessment of what is being portrayed in Scripture. The image we come up with is probably a person who is weak and frail but willing to sympathize with our every need and concern. We might even visualize a weak frail person who is content to hang around a funeral home and cry with everyone who comes through the door.

When the Scripture uses the word comforter there is an attempt to say something far more significant. The Greek word for Comforter is Parakletos which means: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- One called alongside for the purpose of assistance (Like a big brother)
- One who pleads another's cause before a judge (He is our legal representation)
- A counselor for the purpose of a defense (He is our defense lawyer when we stand accused) (Talk about pre-paid legal fees)
- A legal assistant (He researches all similar cases and furnishes the information to the attorney)
- An intercessor (He is our most able advocate at Heaven's court)
- A helper (Someone to assist in all situations)

Do you get the picture? The comforter is a constant abiding presence which is capable of assisting the believer in all situations!

Life can be extremely difficult, not to mention complicated! All of us experience times in life when we need the help of others. Though some people attempt to isolate themselves, we are not engineered to deal with life's problems on our own! God said of Adam, [Genesis 2:18, 21-23](#) (NKJV) *"And the LORD God said, **'It is not good that man should be alone; I will make him a helper comparable to him.'**"²¹ And the LORD God caused a deep sleep to fall on Adam, and he slept; and He took one of his ribs, and closed up the flesh in its place.²² Then the rib which the LORD God had taken from man **He made into a woman**, and He brought her to the man.²³ And Adam said: "This is now bone of my bones And flesh of my flesh; She shall be called Woman, Because she was taken out of Man."*

It is a wonderful thing to have family or friends who are closely enough connected that we feel free to enlist their help in difficult times. To walk through an extremely difficult time in life is bad enough, but to walk it out alone is even worse. Why would anyone resist such help?

We should receive the Holy Spirit to access maximum assistance from the Heavenly Father!

WE SHOULD RECEIVE THE HOLY SPIRIT BECAUSE HE CONVICTS US OF SIN!

Most Christians would agree that a person cannot come to Christ apart from the conviction of the Holy Spirit. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)** John 6:44 (NKJV) ***"No one can come to Me unless the Father who sent Me draws him..."*** How does the Father draw us? John 16:5-8 (LB) ***"But now I am going away to the one who sent me; and none of you seems interested in the purpose of my going; none wonders why. 6 Instead you are only filled with sorrow. 7 But the fact of the matter is that it is best for you that I go away, for if I don't, the Comforter won't come. If I do, he will—for I will send him to you. 8 "And when he has come he will convince the world of its sin, and of the availability of God's goodness, and of deliverance from judgment."*** A great portion of the work of the Holy Spirit is to make the unrepentant sinner fully aware of his hopeless eternal condition.

Another aspect of the work of the Holy Spirit is to make Christians aware of their failures and sins! That's right, when we who are believers, fail, the Holy Spirit becomes the still small voice inside us which causes us to feel guilty concerning our sin. His purpose is not to make us feel like a failure but to bring us to repentance.

Listen to the importance of walking in the Spirit of God each day of our lives. Galatians 5:16 (NKJV) ***"I say then: Walk in the Spirit, and you shall not fulfill the lust of the flesh."*** Galatians 5:24-25 (NKJV) ***"And those who are Christ's have crucified the flesh with its passions and desires. 25 If we live in the Spirit, let us also walk in the Spirit."***

If it is true that a portion of the work of the Holy Spirit is to help us walk out our life in Christ, why would we not want as much of the influence of the Spirit in our lives as possible? Sometimes what the Word does not say is almost as important as what it does say. If it says that ***"If we walk in the Spirit we will not fulfill the lusts of the flesh"***, then it also infers that ***"If we do not walk in the Spirit we will fulfill the lusts of the flesh."***

Those who have a passion to walk as close to Jesus as possible will eventually find the path to Holy Spirit baptism. Once they step into this new dimension many things will change in their lives but one of the most significant changes will be the heightened awareness, of what pleases God and what does not please God.

We should receive the Holy Spirit to allow Him to convict us of our sin!

CONCLUSION:

We should seek to receive the Holy Spirit for all of these reasons and many more.
Are we ready to receive the fullness of the Spirit? (LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE END OF THE SESSION)

FACILITATOR'S QUESTIONS:

- 1) Who is the baptism in the Holy Spirit for?
- 2) Who is qualified to receive the baptism in the Holy Spirit?
- 3) How does one know when they have received the baptism in the Holy Spirit?
- 4) What are some of the advantages of being filled with the Holy Spirit?
- 5) There are two ways to pray in the Spirit, what are they?
- 6) What are people generally called when they have experienced the baptism in the Holy Spirit?

NEXTSTEPS 101
LIVING A LIFE OF SERVICE
(6 of 8)

BLUE – POWER POINT PRESENTATION

BROWN – INSTRUCTIONS TO TECHNICIAN

TEXT: **Romans 12:1** (NKJV) *"I beseech you therefore, brethren, by the mercies of God, that you present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable to God, which is your reasonable service."*

Matthew 25:37-40 (NKJV) *"Then the righteous will answer Him, saying, 'Lord, when did we see You hungry and feed You, or thirsty and give You drink?'³⁸ 'When did we see You a stranger and take You in, or naked and clothe You?'³⁹ 'Or when did we see You sick, or in prison, and come to You?'⁴⁰ "And the King will answer and say to them, 'Assuredly, I say to you, inasmuch as you did it to one of the least of these My brethren, you did it to Me."*

Matthew 23:10-12 (KJV) *"Neither be ye called masters: for one is your Master, even Christ. 11 But he that is greatest among you shall be your servant. 12 And whosoever shall exalt himself shall be abased; and he that shall humble himself shall be exalted."*

INTRO: Our society is geared toward leadership rather than serving. Everywhere you turn you see a new best-selling book or a conference being advertised, all having to do with leadership. **John Maxwell** said *"everything rises and falls on leadership."* I am certainly not in a position to dispute Mr. Maxwell but I believe the bedrock of our effectiveness is tied to what Jesus said in Matthew 23:10-12 (KJV) *"Neither be ye called masters: for one is your Master, even Christ. 11 But he that is greatest among you shall be your servant. 12 And whosoever shall exalt himself shall be abased; and he that shall humble himself shall be exalted."*

Someone said *"He who bows lowest, stands the tallest."* Jesus not only preached and taught servanthood but He modeled it as well. **Everywhere Jesus went He found a way to serve the people: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- He preached in their Synagogues
- He taught them valuable lessons
- He healed the sick

Most of us have become saturated with lessons on how to be a good leader, what we need is to figure out how to incorporate a little servanthood with it. [Servant leadership is the most effective kind of leadership.](#) **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)** Pastors and lay leaders alike should be willing to get their hands dirty in the work of God, right along with the people they are leading. Being a good leader will not release us from our God-given responsibility of serving God's people. Jesus said to Peter... [John 21:15](#) (NKJV) *"So when they had eaten breakfast, Jesus said to Simon Peter, **"Simon, son of Jonah, do you love Me more than these?"** He said to Him, "Yes, Lord; You know that I love You." He said to him, **"Feed My lambs."*** The writer of Romans calls our service to God's people *"our reasonable service."*

I want us to look at seven Biblical reasons for serving...

WE ARE TO SERVE AS A DEMONSTRATION OF OUR WORSHIP TO GOD!

[Romans 12:1](#) (AMP) *"I APPEAL to you therefore, brethren, and beg of you in view of [all] the mercies of God, to make a decisive dedication of your bodies [presenting all your members and faculties] as a living sacrifice, holy (devoted, consecrated) and well pleasing to God, which is your reasonable (rational, intelligent) service and spiritual worship."*

[Matthew 25:40](#) (NKJV) ***"... inasmuch as you did it to one of the least of these My brethren, you did it to Me."***

Here we are told that service is worship. All of us know that if we desire the presence of the Lord we should worship Him. [Psalm 22:3](#) (KJV) *"But thou art holy, O thou that inhabitest the praises of Israel."*

[Our service to others is a method of worship to God.](#) I long to serve the Lord for the purpose of offering worship to Him!

WE ARE TO SERVE AS A DEMONSTRATION OF GOD'S LOVE FOR OTHERS!

[Peter 4:10-11](#) (NLV) *"God has given each of you a gift. Use it to help each other. This will show God's love. ¹¹If a man preaches, let him do it with God speaking through him. If a man helps others, let him do it with the strength God gives. So in all things God may be honored through Jesus Christ. Shining-greatness and power belong to Him forever. Let it be so."*

The Bible makes very clear the love of God for all the people of this world.

(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE) John 3:16 (KJV)

"For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting life."

When Jesus left the earth He gave His followers a mandate. John 14:12 (NKJV)

"Most assuredly, I say to you, he who believes in Me, the works that I do he will do also; and greater works than these he will do, because I go to My Father."

There is no greater way to manifest the love of our Heavenly Father than to love someone who does not deserve it! **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE**

NEXT SLIDE) Matthew 5:46 (NKJV) ***"For if you love those who love you, what reward have you?"***

I wish to serve Him for the purpose of demonstrating His love for others! (I pray every day that as I reach out and touch the people of this church that when I pull my hands back, they will have the fingerprints of God on their life because He has touched them through me!)

WE SHOULD SERVE TO DEMONSTRATE THE ABILITIES GOD HAS GIVEN TO US!

Each of us was born with certain abilities. These abilities are normally referred to as our natural gifts. God gives us our natural abilities at birth because He has something specific in mind for us to do with our lives. Psalm 139:13-16 (LB)

"You made all the delicate, inner parts of my body and knit them together in my mother's womb. 14 Thank you for making me so wonderfully complex! It is amazing to think about. Your workmanship is marvelous—and how well I know it. 15 You were there while I was being formed in utter seclusion! 16 You saw me before I was born and scheduled each day of my life before I began to breathe. Every day was recorded in your book!"

When we accept Christ, God gives us a host of spiritual gifts which will work in tandem with our natural abilities, catapulting us into a position of achieving His destiny for our lives. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** Ephesians 2:10 (NKJV) ***"For we are His workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand that we should walk in them."***

God takes very seriously the manner in which we use our gifts and abilities. He gave us the gifts and abilities we possess to do a very specific work for Him. Luke

12:48 (NKJV) ***"For everyone to whom much is given, from him much will be required; and to whom much has been committed, of him they will ask the more."***

When we function in the specific role He has pre-determined for us, we demonstrate the fact that our gifts and abilities are not really our own, they are His. When we reach the point of serving in our PLACE we will experience the anointing of the Holy Spirit and the favor of the Lord. When this happens we will accomplish feats that are phenomenal. At this point it is imperative that we recognize and verbalize the fact that the glory belongs to God and not us.

Someday we will all give an account for what we did with what we had! **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** Romans 14:12 (NKJV) ***"So then each of us shall give account of himself to God."***

I wish to serve my Father for the purpose of demonstrating His ability, not mine!

WE SHOULD SERVE TO DEMONSTRATE OUR FAITHFULNESS TO GOD!

None of us would question God's faithfulness to us. The \$64,000.00 question is our faithfulness to Him. God is faithful even when we are not but life is made richer and fuller when we reciprocate His faithfulness. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)**

When we serve others our service is a demonstration of our faithfulness to Him. Jesus placed a premium on faithfulness. Matthew 25:14-30 (AMP) ***"For it is like a man who was about to take a long journey, and he called his servants together and entrusted them with his property. ¹⁵To one he gave five talents [probably about \$5,000], to another two, to another one--to each in proportion to his own ^[a]personal ability. Then he departed and left the country. ¹⁶He who had received the five talents went at once and traded with them, and he gained five talents more. ¹⁷And likewise he who had received the two talents--he also gained two talents more. ¹⁸But he who had received the one talent went and dug a hole in the ground and hid his master's money. ¹⁹Now after a long time the master of those servants returned and settled accounts with them. ²⁰And he who had received the five talents came and brought him five more, saying, Master, you entrusted to me five talents; see, here I have gained five talents more. ²¹His master said to him, Well done, you upright (honorable, ^[b]admirable) and faithful servant! You have been faithful and trustworthy over a little; I will put you in charge of much. Enter into and share the joy (the delight, the ^[c]blessedness) which your master***

enjoys. ²²And he also who had the two talents came forward, saying, Master, you entrusted two talents to me; here I have gained two talents more. ²³His master said to him, Well done, you upright (honorable, ^[d]admirable) and faithful servant! You have been faithful and trustworthy over a little; I will put you in charge of much. Enter into and share the joy (the delight, the ^[e]blessedness) which your master enjoys. ²⁴He who had received one talent also came forward, saying, Master, I knew you to be a harsh and hard man, reaping where you did not sow, and gathering where you had not winnowed [the grain]. ²⁵So I was afraid, and I went and hid your talent in the ground. Here you have what is your own. ²⁶But his master answered him, You wicked and lazy and idle servant! Did you indeed know that I reap where I have not sowed and gather [grain] where I have not winnowed? ²⁷Then you should have invested my money with the bankers, and at my coming I would have received what was my own with interest. ²⁸So take the talent away from him and give it to the one who has the ten talents. ²⁹For to everyone who has will more be given, and he will be ^[d]furnished richly so that he will have an abundance; but from the one who does not have, even what he does have will be taken away. ³⁰And throw the good-for-nothing servant into the outer darkness; there will be weeping and grinding of teeth."

Two things are clearly revealed in this Scripture: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- There is a reward to be gained from serving faithfully (First two servants)
- There is a consequence for lack of faithfulness (Last servant)

Most people who never get around to faithfully serving others have good intentions. They are waiting for a more convenient time. The enemy will make sure you never get enough time, you must make time.

Unfaithful people lose out because of neglect. [Hebrews 2:3](#) (NKJV) "*How shall we escape if we neglect so great a salvation?*"

We must re-prioritize our entire life if necessary. [Faithful service is essential both now and in eternity.](#) **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** Speaking of the parable of the talents, Jesus says the following of the faithful servants. [Matthew 25:21](#) (NKJV) "*His lord said to him, 'Well done, good and faithful servant; you were faithful over a few things, I will make you ruler over many things. Enter into the joy of your lord.'*"

I desire to serve my Lord for the purpose of demonstrating my faithfulness to Him!

WE SHOULD SERVE TO DEMONSTRATE GOD'S PLAN FOR OUR LIVES!

God is THE master planner! Some Pentecostal folks do not believe in planning, they think we should constantly fly by the seat of our pants. They cannot bring themselves to believe that God could be in the middle of anything that is organized or planned. I've heard people say, *"I visited that church but they had a program to go by and I want to go somewhere the Holy Spirit is allowed to move!"* I pray God would deliver us from this kind of stinking thinking.

God planned the world, and then built it according to His specifications. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** He planned each day of the world and it is continuing to go according to His schedule. He also planned each day of every person who would ever live on this globe! [Jeremiah 29:11](#) (NLT) *"For I know the plans I have for you," says the LORD. "They are plans for good and not for disaster, to give you a future and a hope."*

If God could build the blueprint for the world, then create it according to his rendering; if He could plan each day of my life before I was a twinkle in my father's eye; surely He can speak to me a few days in advance to develop an order of service!

With that said, let me quickly raise a voice of caution. We must always make sure we are operating on His agenda rather than expecting Him to operate within the restrictions of ours.

God has a plan for each of us, it is essential that we discover and pursue that plan. A very sad fact in the modern church is that [most people never discover their purpose in life or ministry](#).

No matter how long you have been in this church I want to issue a challenge: If you are not absolutely sure what God's purpose for your life is, enroll in our PLACE class now!

When we passionately serve God we demonstrate the fact that He has a plan for us. We also demonstrate, we know what that plan entails. **(PLAY PLACE VIDEO)**

As a builder, it always gave me a great deal of pleasure to begin a home with nothing but a blueprint and raw material and then walk away from the job having completed the project according to specifications.

It must give our Father, who is the master builder, a great deal of pleasure when He transfers natural abilities and spiritual gifts into a believer, to see those gifts and abilities used to their maximum potential!

I want to serve Him for the purpose of demonstrating His plan for my life.

WE SHOULD SERVE TO DEMONSTRATE OUR FAITH AND COMMITMENT TO GOD!

We have a tendency to constantly focus on what we can get rather than what we can give. To the modern church God has become a giant Santa Claus in the sky. We want to know, what is in this for me? The Mission and Purpose statement of the modern church seems to be “Gimme... Gimme... Gimme...” We are strong on getting but weak on serving!

The late President John F. Kennedy said, *"Ask not what your country can do for you, but what you can do for your country."* **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)**

The most effective way to demonstrate our faith and commitment to the Lord is through service to Him. It is impossible for one human being to serve another on an ongoing basis without loving them and being fully committed to them. (Use Sister Murphy as an example)

My service to the Lord should not be out of responsibility but love. If my service to Him is based on love rather than duty, I will be able to serve Him with joy and not grudgingly. What constitutes serving the Lord? **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Our worship is an act of service
- Our giving is an act of service
- Living a Godly life is an act of service
- Ministering to others is an act of service

Listen to what Paul told Timothy. **1 Timothy 4:14-16 (NLT)** *"Do not neglect the spiritual gift you received through the prophecies spoken to you when the elders of the church laid their hands on you. 15 Give your complete attention to these matters. Throw yourself into your tasks so that everyone will see your progress. 16 Keep a close watch on yourself and on your teaching. Stay true to what is right, and God will save you and those who hear you."*

Many people start well, look good in the race, run rapidly, but they are not finishers! **God does not reward starters He rewards finishers! (LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** Matthew 10:22 (NKJV) ***“And you will be hated by all for My name’s sake. But he who endures to the end will be saved.”***

Our faith and commitment being demonstrated through steady devotion and service brings glory and honor to our Lord. What could bring more glory to God than His servants finishing well? (I recently attended the funeral service of C.A. Reece who was the father of Sister Jackie Bates. At 92 he was placed in a nursing home, so he started preaching there!) (Sis. Eubanks – When she could no longer preach to a crowd, she preached to an audience of one... Me!)

I must serve the Lord to demonstrate my faith in Him and my commitment to Him!

WE SHOULD SERVE TO DEMONSTRATE GOD'S GIFTS TO EQUIP AND STRENGTHEN THE BODY!

In the Scriptures, the church has a very unique and prestigious place. The church is the organism which God has chosen to fulfill His program on earth. Modern day Christians have become so conditioned to the church being nothing more than another social club that they think nothing of speaking evil of the church and standing in the way of its progress. We should never forget, **outside the Holy Spirit, the church is the mightiest force on this planet. (LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)**

Not one of us would consider taking on the United States military, expecting to win. Yet, many Christians attack the church as if it were just another civic club they hope to manipulate. (Korah’s Rebellion)

Let me sound an alarm, one better think long and hard before throwing their support behind anyone who wants to attack a church. I am not the head of the church, Jesus is! Before one becomes involved in such an activity they should sit down and read Numbers chapter sixteen! (Korah's Rebellion)

I have made these observations regarding the church to say, **all ministry should flow through the local church. (LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** If one is going to launch a ministry they should do so with the recognition and support of a local church and a local pastor. One should submit completely to a church and pastor and when they issue a word of caution one should follow the advice given.

To refuse to do this is an act of rebellion against the church and the Lord of the church and the effort will fail sooner or later.

The gifts and abilities we spoke of earlier were not given to us so we could bless ourselves, they were given to us to minister to the world and to equip and strengthen the church. If you know something about the Word that I do not know, you owe it to me to share it with me. If I know something you do not know I owe it to you to share it with you.

The same thing applies to our gifts! There are people sitting all over this sanctuary who are loaded down with talent but have not offered it to this church! I admonish you to take your light out from under the bushel today, set it on a lamp stand so all of us can benefit from the illumination it will surely provide.

One of my favorite Scriptures can be found in the book of Ephesians. [Ephesians 4:11-13](#) (NLT) ***"He is the one who gave these gifts to the church: the apostles, the prophets, the evangelists, and the pastors and teachers. 12 Their responsibility is to equip God's people to do his work and build up the church, the body of Christ, 13 until we come to such unity in our faith and knowledge of God's Son that we will be mature and full grown in the Lord, measuring up to the full stature of Christ."***

I should desire to serve for the purpose of equipping and strengthening the body of Christ!

CONCLUSION:

Serving God and serving His Church introduces great satisfaction in the life of His servants! **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE END OF THE SESSION)**

FACILITATOR'S QUESTIONS:

- 1) Who is called to serve?
- 2) Why do we need to serve?
- 3) Where do we need to serve?
- 4) What is Christian ministry?
- 5) What is our motivation for service?
- 6) Who did Jesus say would be greatest in the Kingdom of God?

NEXTSTEPS 101 REACHING OUT (7 of 8)

BLUE – POWER POINT PRESENTATION

BROWN – INSTRUCTIONS TO TECHNICIAN

TEXT: John 3:16-17 (NKJV) *"For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life."* ¹⁷ *"For God did not send His Son into the world to condemn the world, but that the world through Him might be saved."*

1 Corinthians 1:18 (NKJV) *"For the message of the cross is foolishness to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God."*

Romans 1:16 (NKJV) *"For I am not ashamed of the gospel of Christ, for it is the power of God to salvation for everyone who believes, for the Jew first and also for the Greek."*

INTRO: In a recent ABC News poll, **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)** *"62 percent of Americans never attend church, except for weddings and funerals."* That stat climbs to over *"70 percent among 18-30 year olds."* Much of the growth in the American church is biological or transfer rather than conversion growth. In fact, Barna Research shows that *"more than 80 percent of the current growth registered by Protestant churches in America is biological or transfer growth."* **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** This is an alarming and devastating fact, which is crippling the cause of Christ within His Kingdom.

Jesus never intended for His church to be an inward turned group of people who invest far more energy and resources in their own comfort than anything else. Jesus intended for His church to be an outward looking community of believers who value the salvation of the lost above all else.

How do I know whether I am in a church that is focused inward or outward?

The measurement I would use to determine whether I am in an inward or outward focused church would be:

Inward focused churches: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Dedicate over 60% of their time, energy and resources on themselves
- Are fundamentally self-centered churches (Sing my songs - Paint it my color - The carpet has to be red because it represents the blood of Jesus)
- Allow their memories to become bigger than their dreams (The Israelites – They remembered the food and forgot the slavery! “We wept when we remembered Zion)
- Fight to preserve propriatorship (If we grow we won't know everyone – A man once told me, “*There was a time I could stand at the door and call everyone by their first name, now I don't know 10% of these people*”)
- Generally have severe control problems (Who is going to be in charge?) (This is not your church, nor my church; this is the Lord’s church!)

Outward focused churches: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Spend more than 35% of their time and resources on their community and world missions
- Are fundamentally selfless churches (Always looking for an opportunity to get involved in the community) (Health Fair)
- Sacrifice personal preferences to evangelize the lost (Each church must ask what it will take to attract the lost of its community)
- Accept change if it will enhance the vision and contribute to world evangelism (We like change, we just resist it at church)
- Willing for the Pastor’s role to change in order to grow and become what God would have them to be - Ephesians 4:11-13 (NKJV) ***“And He Himself gave some to be apostles, some prophets, some evangelists, and some pastors and teachers, 12 for the equipping of the saints for the work of ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ, 13 till we all come to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, to a perfect man, to the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ;”***

Follow me very closely for a moment because I do not want you to think I am contradicting myself. While the church must discover what it will take to reach its community, the best method of doing this is to pray and get God's plan, because He knows better than anyone what will work best. (Use two blueprints for object lesson)

I'm afraid the church in its desperate attempt to grow has adopted a one size fits all mentality. This happens because the church is by and large void of the leadership of the Holy Spirit and being run like a business by carnal Christians. We have

bought into a seeker sensitive mentality! Rather than giving the world what they need we attempt to give them what they want!

On the other hand there are those who seem to have a seeker hostile mentality where we do our thing and couldn't care less about what the world thinks of our program. It's like saying I am building Studebakers even though no one is buying Studebakers! In this scenario, if you are going to stay in business you had better handle some Ford and Chevrolet parts as well! The church must quit answering questions which are not being asked! We must craft our methods to attract the community, while keeping our message pure. (Seeker sensitive versus seeker hostile)

I am fully aware that methods must change but we need to be very cautious how far we swing toward allowing the world to run the church.

Larry Lewis, national facilitator of denominations for Mission America, makes the following observation: *"There's a consumer mentality that says I go to church not to give anything or to be challenged or instructed, but to be helped, and there's a tendency to turn the prophetic message and its challenge into the ear-tickling message of self-help lectures with very little Biblical content. You can't reduce ministry to that, we have a prophetic role that we must fulfill if we are to be true to our calling... I can't imagine Nehemiah or Job or Amos going down the street with a clipboard in their hand asking, 'What would you like for us to preach about?'"* Before we get too excited about this, we tend to speak out against the church becoming too seeker sensitive, yet we seek out a church that has a certain worship style and a certain preaching style because that is what we want!

The responsibility of leadership is to discover the plan God has for the church to reach its community and its world, and then run with the plan! The responsibility of laity is that of follow-ship.

Christ centered leadership will always be outwardly focused. God's heart is to reach the lost! The heart of leadership and laity alike should be the same.

I want to give you one more alarming statistic before I move on: A national survey conducted by author [Thom Rainer](#), says *"eight out of ten un-churched men and women said they would go to church if only someone would invite them."*

I want us to look at seven Biblical reasons for reaching out...

WE SHOULD REACH OUT BECAUSE WE HAVE BEEN COMMANDED TO DO SO!

During my tenure as a Pastor I have been called upon countless times to accompany a family to the bedside of a loved one who was about to slip into eternity. If the person who is about to depart this life is at all cognizant, I have never seen it fail that they will always give parting instructions to the next of kin. When the final instructions begin to fall from the lips of the person who is staring eternity in the whites of the eyes, the thoughts are always carefully framed as if the words they are speaking were their most treasured commodity on the earth. (Man who made his wife promise to bury him with all of his money... Man who said this is my house, my car, my money...)

The reason these times are viewed so seriously is because the person is summarizing seventy or eighty years of living into a few sentences. All of a sudden a person possesses the ability to capture all that is important in life within a couple of paragraphs. They are taking care of unfinished business. [Ecclesiastes 12:13](#) (KJV) ***“Let us hear the conclusion of the whole matter, fear God and keep His commandments for this is the whole duty of man.”***

It is in this same setting that our Lord speaks to the first century Apostles as well as all those who would follow in their footsteps. He carefully frames His thoughts and utters a few sentences that would forever change the course of the world, as well as to give marching orders to many generations of Christians who would dare to follow Him. [Mark 16:15](#) (NKJV) ***“And He said to them, “Go into all the world and preach the gospel to every creature.”*** Please understand this is not *“The great suggestion”*; this is *“The great commission!”* I am afraid we have taken a view of this Scripture which does not do justice to the intent behind the words of our Lord.

[Parting instructions are the most important instructions.](#) Jesus summed it all up by telling the disciples to ***“Go preach the Gospel to every creature.”*** [Mark 16:20](#) (KJV) tells us ***“...The Lord confirmed the Word with signs following.”*** If we will furnish the effort, the Lord will furnish the results.

We must reach out, because we have been commanded to do so.

WE SHOULD REACH OUT BECAUSE SINNERS ARE PERISHING!

There is a very dangerous doctrine making the religious circles and it is known as *“Eventual Reconciliation.”* Eventual Reconciliation is quite possibly one of the most dangerous heretical doctrines to make religious circles in the history of the

church. This doctrine says as long as a person does not know the way, God will eventually reconcile them whether or not they have received Christ!

If this doctrine were true:

- God would never have revealed to Adam the fact that because of his sin, he was lost and in need of a savior!
- God would never have sent a prophet!
- God would never have sent a priest!
- God would never have demanded the shedding of blood as the ransom for sin!
- God would never have sent His Son, Jesus!

If this doctrine were true, it would be in the best interest of the world to:

- Shut every church down!
- Silence every preacher!
- Bring every missionary home!
- Never preach the gospel on the airwaves!
- Enact the death penalty for witnessing!

How ridiculous could one be? Yet, we have come to the place where many churches will not refer to people as "lost" they are "missing". Thom Rainer says *"We have dumbed down church so much to the point there are Christians asking 'Why do I want to be a part of something that means so little?'"*

Let me emphasize to you a major truth of the Gospel, all who have not received Christ are eternally lost! Psalm 9:17 (NKJV) "The wicked shall be turned into hell, And all the nations that forget God." Revelation 20:15 (NKJV) "And anyone not found written in the Book of Life was cast into the lake of fire."

We must reach out because all who have not heard and received are perishing! Mark 16:15-16 (KJV) "And he said unto them, Go ye into all the world, and preach the gospel to every creature. 16 He that believeth and is baptized shall be saved; but he that believeth not shall be damned."

WE SHOULD REACH OUT BECAUSE OUR POSITION URGES US TO DO SO!

With every new job assignment, comes new responsibility. When you merge the assignment and the responsibility you get what is known as a position. With the new position comes a measure of authority, but the authority is quickly followed by a new level of expectation!

When a person becomes a believer they are given a new position. We are no longer lost we are saved! With the new position of redemption we become Ambassadors for Christ! [2 Corinthians 5:18-21](#) (NKJV) *"Now all things are of God, who has reconciled us to Himself through Jesus Christ, and has given us the ministry of reconciliation,¹⁹ that is, that God was in Christ reconciling the world to Himself, not imputing their trespasses to them, and has committed to us the word of reconciliation.²⁰ Now then, we are ambassadors for Christ, as though God were pleading through us: we implore you on Christ's behalf, be reconciled to God.²¹ For He made Him who knew no sin to be sin for us, that we might become the righteousness of God in Him."*

Other than a President or the Head of State an Ambassador is the highest ranking diplomatic representative from one country to another. Paul says we are Ambassadors for Christ! If this is true, what does our new position demand that we do? The Ambassador takes all his marching orders from the Head of State! The Ambassador does not set his own agenda; he champions the agenda of the Head of State!

What is the agenda of our Father? [John 3:16-17](#) (NKJV) *"For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life.¹⁷ "For God did not send His Son into the world to condemn the world, but that the world through Him might be saved."*

- After Jesus delivered Legion, he went home and told his friends what had happened to him and the Bible says *"They did marvel."*
- Andrew went and found Peter and told him!
- Phillip told his brother Nathaniel!
- The Samaritan woman told everyone!
- [Luke 14:16-24](#) (NKJV) *"Then He said to him, "A certain man gave a great supper and invited many,¹⁷ "and sent his servant at supper time to say to those who were invited, 'Come, for all things are now ready.'¹⁸ "But they all with one accord began to make excuses. The first said to him, 'I have bought a piece of ground, and I must go and see it. I ask you to have me excused.'¹⁹ "And another said, 'I have bought five yoke of oxen, and I am going to test them. I ask you to have me excused.'²⁰ "Still another said, 'I have married a wife, and therefore I cannot come.'²¹ "So that servant came and reported these things to his master. Then the master of the house, being angry, said to his servant, 'Go out quickly into the streets and lanes of the city, and bring in here the poor and the maimed and the lame and the blind.'²² "And the servant said, 'Master, it is done as you*

commanded, and still there is room.'²³ "Then the master said to the servant, 'Go out into the highways and hedges, and compel them to come in, that my house may be filled.'²⁴ 'For I say to you that none of those men who were invited shall taste my supper.' "

These people had to tell the story because their position urged them to do so! The witness is under obligation to tell the truth!

We should reach out because our position as Ambassadors urges us to do so!

WE SHOULD REACH OUT BECAUSE THE NATURE OF THE GOSPEL DEMANDS IT!

When we speak about the nature of a thing, we are referring to the fact that certain things are the way they are because that is the way they are meant to be. By definition, the word nature means, the quality or qualities that make something what it is. **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- The nature of a dog is to bark
- The nature of a cat is to meow
- The nature of an ant is to work
- The nature of a lion is to be a predator
- The nature of a bear is to sleep all winter
- The nature of a pig is to wallow in the mud
- The nature of a sinner is to be bound by sin
- The nature of the gospel is to redeem sinners

1 Corinthians 1:18 (NKJV) *"For the message of the cross is foolishness to those who are perishing, but to us who are being saved it is the power of God."*

Romans 1:16 (NKJV) *"For I am not ashamed of the gospel of Christ, for it is the power of God to salvation for everyone who believes, for the Jew first and also for the Greek."*

The word Gospel means good news! It is the good news of salvation from sin through the death, burial and resurrection of our Lord and Savior, Jesus Christ!

When the prophet Ezekiel prophesied the Word to the dry bones in Ezekiel 37:

- Every bone made a mad dash to connect to its counterpart...
- Flesh came upon the bones...
- Skin covered the flesh...
- Breath came into dead corpses...

- The dead were transformed into the living...

Why? Because it is the nature of the gospel to give life!!!

The Gospel is: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Deliverance for the bound...
- The balm in Gilead...
- The remedy for the snake bite...
- The cure for sin's cancer...
- Man's only hope...

We must reach out because it is the nature of the gospel to do so!

WE SHOULD REACH OUT BECAUSE THE HARVEST FIELD IS CALLING US!

In the Scripture, when you read of the harvest the Bible is speaking of something more precious than a little grain in the field, it is speaking of eternal souls who are coming to a place of being lost. (My experience driving a combine)

One thing I learned while pastoring in a farming community is that you never plan special services during sowing time or harvest time. At harvest time, nothing is more important than gathering the crops! It is a matter of survival!

Listen to what Jesus has to say about the harvest! **John 4:35 (NKJV) *"Do you not say, 'There are still four months and then comes the harvest'? Behold, I say to you, lift up your eyes and look at the fields, for they are already white for harvest!"***

When wheat is white in the field, this means it is on the verge of being overripe and any little movement in the stalk, or radical weather change could cause the crop to be lost! Time is of the essence; reapers are needed; the crop must be harvested! Jesus made a prayer request with regard to this. **Matthew 9:37-38 (NKJV) *"Then He said to His disciples, 'The harvest truly is plentiful, but the laborers are few.38 Therefore pray the Lord of the harvest to send out laborers into His harvest.'"*** The church should continue praying this prayer while attempting to be a part of answering the request.

The word, "send" in verse 38 means, to thrust with a sense of urgency. This term is used in much the same way a football coach would grab an offensive player by

the nape of the neck, and send him onto the field of play as time lapses from the game. The coach sends the player onto the field with such urgency that the coach's momentum requires that he go part way out onto the field of play with the player.

The harvest field is calling to the church for extra workers to reap the golden grain of the harvest!

According to Barna Research: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- A typical church member contributes \$20.00 per year toward global outreach.
- The average American spends \$164.00 per year on soft drinks. (More than 8 times what they give to missions)

We should reach out because the harvest field is calling us!

WE SHOULD REACH OUT BECAUSE HELL IS REQUESTING IT!

We hear so little about hell that people by and large have determined there is no such place. Hell is a real place! Jesus paints a word picture with regard to this awful place. Luke 16:19-26 (NKJV) *"There was a certain rich man, which was clothed in purple and fine linen, and fared sumptuously every day: 20 And there was a certain beggar named Lazarus, which was laid at his gate, full of sores, 21 And desiring to be fed with the crumbs which fell from the rich man's table: moreover the dogs came and licked his sores. 22 And it came to pass, that the beggar died, and was carried by the angels into Abraham's bosom: the rich man also died, and was buried; 23 And in hell he lift up his eyes, being in torments, and seeth Abraham afar off, and Lazarus in his bosom. 24 And he cried and said, Father Abraham, have mercy on me, and send Lazarus, that he may dip the tip of his finger in water, and cool my tongue; for I am tormented in this flame. 25 But Abraham said, Son, remember that thou in thy lifetime receivedst thy good things, and likewise Lazarus evil things: but now he is comforted, and thou art tormented. 26 And beside all this, between us and you there is a great gulf fixed: so that they which would pass from hence to you cannot; neither can they pass to us, that would come from thence."*

Notice several things about this Scripture: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- This is a story about a rich man and a poor man (The spiritual connotation is the saved and lost)

- Both men died (Vs. 22) *“And it came to pass, that the beggar died - The rich man also died...”* Hebrews 9:27 (NKJV) *“And as it is appointed for men to die once, but after this the judgment.”*
- One went to eternal peace; the other went to eternal punishment (Vs. 22) *“The beggar died, and was carried by the angels into Abraham’s bosom...”* (Vs 22 & 23) *“...The rich man also died, and was buried; 23 And in hell he lift up his eyes, being in torments.”* (All will be divided into only two groups, the lost and the saved)
- One rejoiced; one begged (Vs. 23) *“In hell he lift up his eyes, being in torments, - Seeth Abraham afar off, and Lazarus in his bosom.”* (Speaking of role reversals)
- The rich man followed his life pattern, thinking first of self (Vs. 24) *“Send Lazarus, that he may dip the tip of his finger in water, and cool my tongue...”*
- The rich man experienced the torment of the flames of hell (Vs. 24) *“I am tormented in this flame.”* (Mark 9:43-48 NKJV) *“If your hand causes you to sin, cut it off. It is better for you to enter into life maimed, rather than having two hands, to go to hell, into the fire that shall never be quenched—44 “where 1 ‘Their worm does not die, And the fire is not quenched.’ 45 “And if your foot causes you to sin, cut it off. It is better for you to enter life lame, rather than having two feet, to be cast into hell, into the fire that shall never be quenched—46 “where ‘Their worm does not die, And the fire is not quenched.’ 47 “And if your eye causes you to sin, pluck it out. It is better for you to enter the kingdom of God with one eye, rather than having two eyes, to be cast into hell fire—48 “where ‘Their worm does not die, And the fire is not quenched.’”*
- The rich man experienced eternal separation from God (Vs. 26) *“And beside all this, between us and you there is a great gulf fixed: so that they which would pass from hence to you cannot; neither can they pass to us, that would come from thence.”* (Eternal separation from God will be the worst thing about hell!)

The story does not end there! Luke 16:27-31 (NKJV) *“Then he said, ‘I beg you therefore, father, that you would send him to my father’s house,28 ‘for I have five brothers, that he may testify to them, lest they also come to this place of torment.’29 “Abraham said to him, ‘They have Moses and the prophets; let them hear them.’30 “And he said, ‘No, father Abraham; but if one goes to them from the dead, they will repent.’31 “But he said to him, ‘If they do not hear Moses and the prophets, neither will they be persuaded though one rise from the dead.’”*

The church struggles with evangelism but hell is full of passionate evangelists!

If one goes to hell: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- They must go as an intruder
- They must go against the will of God
- They must go against the prayers of the saints
- They must go against the objections of hell's residents
- They will be lost from the memory of friends and family members who go to heaven

As we sit in this room, poor, lost, doomed souls in hell are screaming for our attention! If they could get the microphone for five minutes they would tell us to reach their families and ours, warning them not to go to hell!

We must reach out because hell is requesting it!

WE SHOULD REACH OUT BECAUSE JOY AWAITS US!

Have you ever watched a program on television where someone has been rescued from certain death?

- Everyone is elated!
- The person who has been rescued is so touched, they are in tears!
- The family members of the person who has been rescued are so ecstatic they are almost giddy!
- The rescuer is so overcome with emotion he is usually camera shy!
- The reporters are taken back a few steps by what appears to be a heroic event!
- Everyone is happy!

Take this same cast of characters, put them together trying to accomplish a task and they will probably have a great deal of trouble making anything work. They will probably find it difficult to get along well after a short amount of time!

What is the difference? The work of saving one's life can bring the personalities, gifts and talents of a group together like nothing else!

The reason so many churches never have anything but strife is because they are seeking everything but the salvation of the lost! When a church unites behind the purpose of winning the lost at any cost, there comes with it a unity that is

unparalleled because this is the purpose of God! We are finally doing what He wants done? [James 5:20](#) (NKJV) "*... Let him know that he who turns a sinner from the error of his way will save a soul from death and cover a multitude of sins.*"

When we meet God face to face He is not going to stretch out His hand and say, "*Thank you for holding out for the green carpet, I was afraid you were going to cave into the blue crowd! Well done, you good and faithful servant!*"

He might say something like this, "*Thank you for persisting in your efforts to win Billy Bob and Linda Sue, their whole family is here in Heaven! Didn't I tell you He who wins souls is wise? Well done, you good and faithful servant, enter into the joys of the Lord! By the way, the pink carpet is ugly but it worked fine!*"

There is a whole lot of stuff the church finds to bicker and argue about that is not going to amount to anything on the Day of Judgment. God must hold His nose during some business meetings! [The church that makes its primary purpose the salvation of the lost will discover God working with them, and great joy will be in the ranks!](#) **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** [Psalm 126:5-6](#) (NKJV) "*Those who sow in tears Shall reap in joy. 6 He who continually goes forth weeping, Bearing seed for sowing, Shall doubtless come again with rejoicing, Bringing his sheaves with him.*" The word "*sheaves*" in this verse has reference to the seed having been sown; the crop is now at full maturity; harvest is in full swing; now the sower becomes the reaper and he has many stalks of the full grown fruit laid across his arm! Get a picture of the sower become reaper, with a beaming smile on his face as he is heading for the barn where he knows the crop will be free from all danger. He sowed in great labor and agony, but he did so knowing harvest time was coming, now the worry lines of his sowing days have been transformed into joy lines as his smile breaks across his entire face!

What makes soul winning so joyful? We are doing the will of the Father! [Proverbs 11:30-31](#) (NKJV) "*The fruit of the righteous is a tree of life, And he who wins souls is wise. 31 If the righteous will be recompensed on the earth, How much more the ungodly and the sinner.*"

[Proverbs 11:18](#) (NKJV) "*The wicked man does deceptive work, But he who sows righteousness will have a sure reward.*"

[Matthew 4:18-19](#) (NKJV) "*And Jesus, walking by the Sea of Galilee, saw two brothers, Simon called Peter, and Andrew his brother, casting a net into the sea;*

for they were fishermen.19 Then He said to them, “Follow Me, and I will make you fishers of men.”

John 15:16 (NKJV) *“You did not choose Me, but I chose you and appointed you that you should go and bear fruit, and that your fruit should remain, that whatever you ask the Father in My name He may give you.”*

- Story of the lost sheep - Luke 15
- Story of the lost silver - Luke 15
- Story of the lost son - Luke 15

What are the common denominators in these stories? Lost things are recovered and as a result, there is great joy!

Every time a person comes to know Christ a party breaks out in Heaven! When an individual finds Christ, it should be party time in the church!

We should reach out because joy awaits us!

CONCLUSION:

Who among us will accept the responsibility and privilege of soul winning?
(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE END OF SESSION)

FACILITATOR’S QUESTIONS:

- 1) Why should we talk about our faith?
- 2) Where should we talk about our faith?
- 3) With whom should we share our faith?
- 4) Should we defend our faith when it is being attacked?
- 5) Is there ever a time when we should keep our faith to ourselves?
- 6) What is the best way for one to share one’s faith?

NEXTSTEPS 101 BECOMING A TITHER (8 of 8)

BLUE – POWER POINT PRESENTATION

BROWN – INSTRUCTIONS TO TECHNICIAN

TEXT: **Malachi 3:8-12** (NKJV) *"Will a man rob God? Yet you have robbed Me! But you say, 'In what way have we robbed You?' In tithes and offerings. 9 You are cursed with a curse, For you have robbed Me, Even this whole nation. 10 Bring all the tithes into the storehouse, That there may be food in My house, And try Me now in this," Says the LORD of hosts, "If I will not open for you the windows of heaven And pour out for you such blessing That there will not be room enough to receive it. 11 "And I will rebuke the devourer for your sakes, So that he will not destroy the fruit of your ground, Nor shall the vine fail to bear fruit for you in the field," Says the LORD of hosts; 12 "And all nations will call you blessed, For you will be a delightful land," Says the LORD of hosts."*

Leviticus 27:30-34 (NLT) *"A tenth of the produce of the land, whether grain or fruit, belongs to the LORD and must be set apart to him as holy. 31 If you want to redeem the LORD's tenth of the fruit or grain, you must pay its value, plus 20 percent. 32 The LORD also owns every tenth animal counted off from your herds and flocks. They are set apart to him as holy. 33 The tenth animal must not be selected on the basis of whether it is good or bad, and no substitutions will be allowed. If any exchange is in fact made, then both the original animal and the substituted one will be considered holy and cannot be redeemed." 34 These are the commands that the LORD gave to the Israelites through Moses on Mount Sinai."*

Luke 6:38 (NLT) *"If you give, you will receive. Your gift will return to you in full measure, pressed down, shaken together to make room for more, and running over. Whatever measure you use in giving—large or small—it will be used to measure what is given back to you."*

2 Corinthians 9:6-7 (NKJV) *"But this I say: He who sows sparingly will also reap sparingly, and he who sows bountifully will also reap bountifully. 7 So let each one give as he purposes in his heart, not grudgingly or of necessity; for God loves a cheerful giver."*

INTRO: I would like to begin this component of this series of lessons by giving you some information on the socio economic status of Americans [according to Barna Research](#): **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- [31%](#) of American adults earn \$30K or less annually, before taxes. (2004)
- [34%](#) of American adults earn between \$30K & \$60K annually, before taxes. (2004)
- [15%](#) of American adults earn between \$60K & \$100K annually, before taxes. (2004)
- [6%](#) of Americans earn more than \$100K annually, before taxes. (2004)
- [37%](#) of Americans report that they are in debt. (2000) (Recently we did a survey in a class at our church which revealed that among the 33 families represented there was in excess of \$1.7 million dollars of junk debt! \$51,515.15 per family! This does not include the house mortgage, the car note, or insurance! America is drowning in a sea of debt!)
- [43%](#) of parents report they are in debt, compared to 34% of non-parents. (2000)
- [32%](#) of adults report they personally struggle with finances. (2001)
- [36%](#) of single adults say they personally struggle with finances, as opposed to 28% of married adults. (2001)
- [32%](#) of Christians, and 44% of non-Christians, indicate that money is very important to them. (1997)
- [33%](#) of born again Christians say it is impossible for them to get ahead in life because of the financial debt they have incurred. (1997)
- [51%](#) of Christians and 54% of non-Christians believe that no matter how they feel about money, it is still the main symbol of success in life. (1997)

Tithing is a subject that most ministers shy away from, simply because they know that the giving nerve is, with most people, a very sensitive nerve.

Teaching on the principles of giving is one of the responsibilities of pastoral ministry. The Bible has much to say about giving; therefore a pastor is indebted to his parishioners to teach good, sound, Biblical, principles for giving. Just because there are people in the church who are uncomfortable with the pastor talking openly about money does not release him from the responsibility of teaching on the subject!

You can tell where a person's heart is by taking a quick look at their checkbook! Jesus reiterated this in [Matthew 6:21](#) (NKJV) ***"For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also."***

Someone asked Willie Sutton, the notorious bank robber, why he robbed so many banks. He replied, *"That's where the money is."* Each of us will leave a clear money trail to the location of our most valuable treasure!

Whether you like it or not, whether you are comfortable or uncomfortable with your pastor talking about money, the fact is that money is something we all deal with every day and we desperately need to use proven Biblical principles to guide our business practices!

The subject of tithing is really not about money alone, it is about a lifestyle of stewardship! George Brazell in his book, *"This is Stewardship"* makes the following statement: *"Stewardship is the sum total of man's attitude and reaction toward the Divine Creator and His creation. God is the owner of all creation, and man is the responsible servant entrusted with, and commissioned to, rightly handle for God His program on earth."* **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)** Stewardship and tithing is all about a proper understanding of ownership; to whom do all our possessions belong? Psalm 24:1 (NKJV) ***"The earth is the LORD's, and all its fullness, The world and those who dwell therein."***

Once we establish true ownership, stewardship becomes much easier. God is the owner of all our possessions! In the Bible, a steward was the business manager for a wealthy person. Remember Joseph, who was the steward (Business Manager) over the house of Potiphar?

The person who has developed a proper understanding of stewardship knows it is more of an attitude than an activity! **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)** 2 Corinthians 9:6-7 (NKJV) ***"But this I say: He who sows sparingly will also reap sparingly, and he who sows bountifully will also reap bountifully. 7 So let each one give as he purposes in his heart, not grudgingly or of necessity; for God loves a cheerful giver."***

Those of us who are operating in a true spirit of stewardship will continually ask ourselves the following question. *"What would God have us to do with what He has entrusted to us?"* If this question rules our life then we get it! We have become the stewards God would have us to be! Once we become the stewards God would have us to be, the tithing debate will be settled in our life. We will tithe because we realize what we have belongs to the Lord, the tithe never belonged to us to begin with therefore all we can do is return the tithe.

There is a terrific need for pastors to step up to the plate and teach Biblical principles of stewardship.

The Lord has required of us as His business managers to invest a minimum of ten percent back into His Kingdom!

WE SHOULD TITHE BECAUSE WE DO NOT WANT TO BE A THIEF!

Malachi 3:8 (NKJV) "*Will a man rob God? Yet you have robbed Me! But you say, 'In what way have we robbed You?' In tithes and offerings.*"

I realize calling anyone who does not tithe a thief is pretty harsh and tends to upset some people. However, as a minister of the Gospel it is not my place to spice up or tone down the Word of God. I am not the author, I am the messenger! Because I am not the author I have no right to edit the contents of this book!

(ILLUSTRATION - HAVE SOMEONE KEEP A \$20.00 BILL FOR ME... IF THEY REFUSE TO GIVE IT BACK, THEY STOLE IT... IF THEY RETURN IT, THEY DID NOT GIVE ME ANYTHING THEY JUST RETURNED WHAT ALREADY BELONGED TO ME)

I am sure the words of God as spoken through the Prophet Malachi did not set well with this Israeli audience either. Being called a thief tends to grate on our human nature. However, we must understand that the words of the Lord as spoken through His prophet were redemptive in nature rather than punitive.

Oftentimes God's Word tends to sting us with a reality check, but if we continue reading it, it offers an alternative course, that if followed, will be replete with blessing! Such is the case in this Scripture. God used His prophet to call these people thieves because they were, they were robbing Him of the first fruits or the tenth of all they acquired. These people were well versed in the law, they were very much aware of their financial responsibility toward God. [Leviticus 27:30-34 \(NLT\)](#) "***A tenth of the produce of the land, whether grain or fruit, belongs to the LORD and must be set apart to him as holy. 31 If you want to redeem the LORD's tenth of the fruit or grain, you must pay its value, plus 20 percent. 32 The LORD also owns every tenth animal counted off from your herds and flocks. They are set apart to him as holy. 33 The tenth animal must not be selected on the basis of whether it is good or bad, and no substitutions will be allowed. If any exchange is in fact made, then both the original animal and the substituted one will be considered holy and cannot be redeemed.***" 34 *These are the commands that the LORD gave to the Israelites through Moses on Mount Sinai.*" [This passage of Scripture makes very clear several things: \(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME\)](#)

- A tenth of all produce belonged to the Lord and was to be considered Holy! Vs. 30 *"**A tenth of the produce of the land, whether grain or fruit, belongs to the LORD and must be set apart to him as holy.**"*
- If the tithe were to be used for other things, when it was returned a twenty percent penalty was to be collected! Vs. 31 *"**If you want to redeem the LORD's tenth of the fruit or grain, you must pay its value, plus 20 percent.**"*
- Every tenth animal belonged to the Lord. They were to number the animals and give the tenth one to the Lord. If it were to be discovered that they had substituted an animal for the tenth one, they were to give the tenth animal as well as the substitute! Vs. 32-33 *"**The LORD also owns every tenth animal counted off from your herds and flocks. They are set apart to him as holy. 33 The tenth animal must not be selected on the basis of whether it is good or bad, and no substitutions will be allowed. If any exchange is in fact made, then both the original animal and the substituted one will be considered holy and cannot be redeemed.**"* Tithing does not require faith and does not necessarily bring with it the blessing of multiplication. Tithing places the believer in a position of releasing the Lord to rebuke the devourer for our sakes. Tithing does not break the spirit of mammon on the money; the believer should bind the spirit of mammon over their income and pronounce the blessing of the Lord upon it. First-fruit requires faith and enacts the blessing of multiplication upon our resources. One can tithe by giving one of ten, any one of ten, but giving the first-fruit requires giving the very first believing there will be nine more! First-fruit requires faith and carries with it the thrill of high adventure with regard to our giving!
- These were not suggestions for the Israelites; they were commandments that Moses received on Mt. Sinai! Vs. 34 *"**These are the commands that the LORD gave to the Israelites through Moses on Mount Sinai.**"* I become extremely amused at people who attempt to put up an argument concerning tithing based on the fact that the Old Testament has much more to say about tithing than does the New Testament. The same people still believe we should live by the Ten Commandments! This Scripture lets us know that Moses received this law concerning giving in exactly the same place and from the same source that he received the Ten Commandments! Christ fulfilled the sacrificial part of the law but did not do away with Old Testament principles!

Based on this Scripture, I submit to you that anyone who is not a tither is stealing from God **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** and therefore is a thief! I seriously doubt if there is anyone in this place that would take money out of the offering receptacle, or be so bold as to hold a gun on the ushers! However, professing Christians do something far worse every week, they hold a gun to God's ribs by not returning the tithe!

Estee Lauder said *"When a person with experience meets a person with money, the person with experience will get the money and the person with money will get experience."* (A deacon once told me that if I was looking for experience they could furnish it. He was right!)

When we have withheld our tithe we have robbed God; we have robbed our neighbor setting down the pew from us; and we have robbed the community in which the church is located; because of the thievery of some of God's people, the church will not have adequate resources to minister to its adherents or the world as it should.

We should return the tithe because a failure to do so makes us a thief!

WE SHOULD TITHE BECAUSE WE HAVE BEEN COMMANDED TO DO SO!

Leviticus 27:30-34 (NLT) *"A tenth of the produce of the land, whether grain or fruit, belongs to the LORD and must be set apart to him as holy. 31 If you want to redeem the LORD's tenth of the fruit or grain, you must pay its value, plus 20 percent. 32 The LORD also owns every tenth animal counted off from your herds and flocks. They are set apart to him as holy. 33 The tenth animal must not be selected on the basis of whether it is good or bad, and no substitutions will be allowed. If any exchange is in fact made, then both the original animal and the substituted one will be considered holy and cannot be redeemed."* 34 *These are the commands that the LORD gave to the Israelites through Moses on Mount Sinai."* **Malachi 3:10 (KJV)** *"Bring all the tithes into the storehouse..."*

It would be literally impossible for a rational person to read these two Scriptures and conclude it is anything other than a commandment! Tithing is not a suggestion for a Christian; it is a commandment to honor God with our finances. This commandment is not because He needs our money, it is because we need to give!

We need to give the tenth part of our income to God because when we do we are acknowledging that what we have does not belong to us, it belongs to God!

The reason these Scriptures sound so much alike is because they have the same author! This has little to do with Moses or Malachi; the words are being spoken by God through His servants!

The first rule of stewardship is to seek God first. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** The person who resists His commands is not seeking Him first, they have an ulterior motive. A true steward will always ask himself, *"What would God want me to do with what He has entrusted to me?"* The answer to this question; He would no doubt want us to invest a portion, at least ten percent, into His Kingdom. A good rule of thumb is 10% to God, 10% to savings, 33% to the government and 47% to live on. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)**

When a person is not a tither, his resources are invested in the following way; **Luke 12:16-19 (NKJV)** *"Then He spoke a parable to them, saying: **'The ground of a certain rich man yielded plentifully.17 'And he thought within himself, saying, 'What shall I do, since I have no room to store my crops?'18 'So he said, 'I will do this: I will pull down my barns and build greater, and there I will store all my crops and my goods.19 'And I will say to my soul, "Soul, you have many goods laid up for many years; take your ease; eat, drink, and be merry."*** Please understand; there is nothing wrong with prosperity. We would all probably like to be a little more prosperous. There is nothing wrong with bumper crops and bigger barns; the point is this man did not consider God in his wealth, he made all his decisions solely on what he believed was best for him.

Listen to how Jesus finishes this parable... **Luke 12:20-21 (NKJV)** ***"But God said to him, 'Fool! This night your soul will be required of you; then whose will those things be which you have provided?'21 "So is he who lays up treasure for himself, and is not rich toward God."***

We have established that we are stewards, God's business managers; stewards are not required to be successful, they are required to be faithful! **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** **1 Corinthians 4:2 (NKJV)** ***"Moreover it is required in stewards that one be found faithful."***

When we tithe we not only acknowledge that everything we have belongs to God, but we begin to walk in obedience to His command, thus placing ourselves in the pathway of a blessing. Listen to the words of Jesus with regard to tithing, **Matthew 23:23 (CEV)** ***"You Pharisees and teachers are show-offs, and you're in for***

trouble! You give God a tenth of the spices from your garden, such as mint, dill, and cumin. Yet you neglect the more important matters of the Law, such as justice, mercy, and faithfulness. These are the important things you should have done, though you should not have left the others undone either." If you are one of those people who are hung up on tithing being an Old Testament principle, Jesus himself says here in the New Testament that the Pharisees should be paying their tithes.

Tithing fulfills a direct commandment of the Lord. We should tithe because we have been commanded to do so!

WE SHOULD TITHE BECAUSE WE DESIRE TO WALK IN OBEDIENCE!

The government of God and man is predicated upon the principle of each person adhering to the laws set forth by God and man. If the law is not followed judgment must be enacted upon the offender. If judgment is not enacted upon the offender eventually anarchy will set in and everyone will be a law unto themselves and will do that which is right in their own eyes!

Everyone in this place is aware that for a society to function properly there must be laws and penalties for breaking those laws. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** If this were not true, you would not be safe anywhere.

As a society crumbles, its laws and penalties become more and more lax. America is headed into a downward spiral for this very reason. When it takes twenty years and a few million dollars to move a person from a death sentence to the death chamber, there is something wrong with that society.

Those who intentionally break laws, whether they are of God or man, are rebellious, thus they become rebels!

From one end of the Bible to the other, obedience is a trait that is heralded as extremely important in the life of the believer. Adam and Eve got into trouble in Genesis for a lack of obedience. It is clear in Revelation 21:8 that the disobedient will be cast into the lake of fire.

We have established the tithing principle to be a commandment of God; therefore, we should do everything in our power to be obedient to His command. Listen to what the Prophet Isaiah has to say on the subject of obedience and lack of it.

Isaiah 1:19-20 (NKJV) *"If you are willing and obedient, You shall eat the good of the land; 20 But if you refuse and rebel, You shall be devoured by the sword";*

For the mouth of the LORD has spoken." What are the principles taught here?
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- To receive what we need from the Lord we must be willing and obedient
"You shall eat the good of the land..."
- If we refuse to do what God has commanded us to do we will be devoured
by the enemy *"If you refuse and rebel, You shall be devoured by the sword..."*
- Isaiah did not speak this, God spoke it *"For the mouth of the LORD has spoken..."*

God desires the same thing from His children as I desire from mine, obedience!
To fail to tithe is to be a disobedient child! To be a disobedient child is to be a rebel.

We should tithe in an effort of walking in obedience to God!

WE SHOULD TITHE BECAUSE WE WANT TO AVOID BEING CURSED!

Malachi 3:9 (NKJV) *"You are cursed with a curse, For you have robbed Me, Even this whole nation."*

The Miriam Webster dictionary defines a curse in the following way: *"To call upon divine or supernatural power to send injury upon."*

There are people who will attempt to speak a curse over your life for the purpose of bringing what they think is bad luck. First of all let me tell you that the enemy cannot curse what God has blessed. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)**

As a Christian, we are capable of speaking curses over our own lives. **Proverbs 18:21** (NKJV) *"Death and life are in the power of the tongue, And those who love it will eat its fruit."* Proverbs 18:21 (CEV) *"Words can bring death or life! Talk too much, and you will eat everything you say."* Proverbs 18:21 (LB) *"Those who love to talk will suffer the consequences. Men have died for saying the wrong thing!"*

I cannot pray long enough or passionately enough to break a curse you are intentionally bringing upon yourself. About the time I get it broken you will fail to tithe and you will be right back where you started. Then how is the curse broken? Through obedience!

WE SHOULD TITHE BECAUSE WE DESIRE TO BE BLESSED!

Malachi 3:10 (KJV) "Bring all the tithes into the storehouse, That there may be food in My house, And try Me now in this," Says the LORD of hosts, "If I will not open for you the windows of heaven And pour out for you such blessing That there will not be room enough to receive it."

The word blessing comes from the Hebrew word **b@raka** (bear-aw-kah), and means: **(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

1. Source of blessing
2. Prosperity
3. Praise of God
4. A gift or present
5. A treaty of peace

A closer look at this verse would reveal our tithing produces:

1. A constant source of blessing – Who would refuse such a source of supply? Our faithfulness in tithing insures the source of divine blessing will be constantly flowing in our direction.
2. Prosperity - Prosperity has been given a bad name by people, who want to abuse it, but the intention of our Heavenly Father is to prosper everyone who has enough integrity and character to do what is right with their finances. Prosperity is having enough, plus a little!
3. Praise of God - When we tithe faithfully, God is proud of us and even praises our works! He brags on us, the end result of God bragging on us is that we will eventually hear it from his own lips, ***"Well done good and faithful servant..."***
4. A gift or present - When we tithe we can get ready to receive gifts from the Lord! Not just at Christmas, on our birthday, or anniversary, but random acts of kindness when it is least expected! He will not be outgiven!
5. A treaty of peace - When we tithe, we enter into a treaty of peace! Peace in our life, home, work, church, and other relationships! Peace with God, ourselves, and His church!

We should tithe because we want to be blessed! In fact His promise is ***"I will open for you the windows of heaven And pour out for you such blessing That there will not be room enough to receive it."***

The blessing of God was apparent upon King Hezekiah when he turned to the Lord and convinced the priests and people to do what was right with their finances. **2 Chronicles 31:2- 10 (NLT) "Hezekiah then organized the priests and Levites into**

divisions to offer the burnt offerings and peace offerings, and to worship and give thanks and praise to the LORD at the gates of the Temple. ³The king also made a personal contribution of animals for the daily morning and evening burnt offerings, as well as for the weekly Sabbath festivals and monthly new moon festivals, and for the other annual festivals as required in the law of the LORD. ⁴In addition, he required the people in Jerusalem to bring the prescribed portion of their income to the priests and Levites, so they could devote themselves fully to the law of the LORD. ⁵The people responded immediately and generously with the first of their crops and grain, new wine, olive oil, honey, and all the produce of their fields. They brought a tithe of all they owned. ⁶The people who had moved to Judah from Israel, and the people of Judah themselves, brought in the tithes of their cattle and sheep and a tithe of the things that had been dedicated to the LORD their God, and they piled them up in great heaps. ⁷The first of these tithes was brought in late spring,^[a] and the heaps continued to grow until early autumn.^[b] ⁸When Hezekiah and his officials came and saw these huge piles, they thanked the LORD and his people Israel! ⁹"Where did all this come from?" Hezekiah asked the priests and Levites. ¹⁰And Azariah the high priest, from the family of Zadok, replied, "Since the people began bringing their gifts to the LORD's Temple, we have had enough to eat and plenty to spare, for the LORD has blessed his people."

When we get blessed by the Lord the end result should be *"There is not room enough to receive it."*

We should tithe in an effort to place ourselves in the path of a blessing!

WE SHOULD TITHE BECAUSE WE WANT THE DEVOURER TO BE REBUKED!

Malachi 3:10-12 (NKJV) *"Bring all the tithes into the storehouse, That there may be food in My house, And try Me now in this," Says the LORD of hosts, "If I will not open for you the windows of heaven And pour out for you such blessing That there will not be room enough to receive it. 11 "And I will rebuke the devourer for your sakes, So that he will not destroy the fruit of your ground, Nor shall the vine fail to bear fruit for you in the field," Says the LORD of hosts; 12 "And all nations will call you blessed, For you will be a delightful land," Says the LORD of hosts."* **Look at the progression in this passage: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- [Bring the tithe](#) - This is our responsibility
- [A blessing is promised for the tither](#) - Blessing always follows obedience
- [The devourer will be rebuked](#) - This is Gods responsibility

There are two very important lessons here that most of us tend to overlook:

1. Even though we pay our tithe or plant the seed through obedience, the enemy of the harvest is never far away. Any good farmer knows that his work is not complete with the sowing of the seed; he must till the ground and tend the crop because the harvest has many enemies! (Drought, wind, hail, temperature and insects)

In this Scripture the enemy of the harvest is identified as "***The devourer.***" Who is the devourer and how should we deal with him?

Webster says the devourer will do the following:

- To eat up greedily or ravenously
- To use up or destroy as if by eating
- To prey upon

Based on this definition the devourer is readily revealed in Scripture. [John 10:10](#) (NKJV) "***The thief does not come except to steal, and to kill, and to destroy. I have come that they may have life, and that they may have it more abundantly.***"

2. The promise in our text is... [Malachi 3:11-12](#) (NKJV) "***I will rebuke the devourer for your sakes, So that he will not destroy the fruit of your ground, Nor shall the vine fail to bear fruit for you in the field,***" Says the LORD of hosts; 12 "***And all nations will call you blessed, For you will be a delightful land,***" Says the LORD of hosts."

A few years ago God taught me a very valuable lesson concerning this Scripture (My story).

The lesson I learned is that it is not my place to rebuke the devourer, it is God's responsibility. My responsibility is to obey by paying my tithe; releasing God to rebuke the devourer on my behalf; stand in faith to believe the crop will come to maturity according to the will of the Heavenly Father.

Webster defines the word rebuke in the following ways: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- To criticize sharply
- To reprimand
- To turn back or keep down

When we release God to rebuke the devourer for our sake, He:

- Gives the devil a tongue lashing! (Bro. Grant - *"Pastor I love it when you give the devil verbal abuse"*)
- Reprimands the devourer. In so doing, He censures him from a position of authority! He tells the devourer what he cannot do, and then makes it stick!
- Reverses the efforts of the devourer, making him pay restitution with penalties! When the Children of Israel left Egypt God made sure they were paid for 400 years of slavery; He then tacked on interest and penalties!

Notice what happens when the devourer is rebuked: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- He will not destroy the fruit of your ground
- The vine will not fail to bear fruit for you
- All nations will call you blessed
- You will be a delightful land

We should pay our tithes for the insurance benefit it offers; God will rebuke the devourer for our sakes!

WE SHOULD TITHE BECAUSE WE WANT THE STOREHOUSE TO HAVE SUFFICIENT RESOURCES TO MINISTER AS IT SHOULD!

Malachi 3:10 (NKJV) "*Bring all the tithes into the storehouse, That there may be food in My house...*" I have intentionally left the issue of resources for the church until last because most people in the church assume that when the pastor speaks on tithing he is attempting to increase the revenues of the church. In this teaching on tithing I have only scratched the surface of the benefits of tithing.

It is true that when more of God's people tithe, the church will have more resources, but that is just one component of what is being said here. Even though I left this lesson until last it is no less important than any of the others.

The word "storehouse" in our Scripture comes from the Hebrew word Owtsar (ot-sow), and means that through tithing **God intends for His house to have: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Treasures of gold and silver
- Supplies of food and drink
- Supplies of weapons
- Resources for times of difficulty

While God intends all these things He never intended for His house to be a bank but rather a resource center. I want to point out several things about the storehouse: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- The storehouse is the place we are instructed to bring our tithe
- The storehouse is the place where we receive Biblical instruction and fellowship (The local church)
- The storehouse should have responsible parties who have been assigned the responsibility of managing its resources according to Biblical guidelines
- Biblical guidelines for storehouse management are: (This is the CT philosophy as well)
 1. Take care of the widows and orphans
 2. Take care of the stranger in the gate
 3. Provide facilities for worshippers
 4. Provide for the discipleship of all believers connected to the storehouse
 5. Provide for the needs of the ministers who labor in the storehouse
This has been the case from early Old Testament times 1 Timothy 5:17-18 (NKJV) ***"Let the elders who rule well be counted worthy of double honor, especially those who labor in the word and doctrine.18 For the Scripture says, "You shall not muzzle an ox while it treads out the grain," and, "The laborer is worthy of his wages."***
 6. Keep two to three months operating capital
 7. Stay out of debt as much as possible

Throughout Scripture we are told repeatedly that all believers are connected through being a part of the body of Christ. Because we are all a part of one body,

what I do has an effect on you, and what you do has an effect on me. This point is clearly illustrated **in the storehouse principle of tithing; (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- If I do not return the tithe it affects everyone in my church, my church is not capable of doing what it could because I have restricted its resources
- If I do not return the tithe I bring the dynamic of a curse into the corporate church (Achan in the Old Testament)
- If I do not return the tithe my church will be somewhat limited in its role in the great commission

Again, I want us to ask ourselves the question, *"If every member of this church were just like me, what kind of church, would this church be?"* **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)**

- Would we be able to provide the various ministries for the families of our church?
- Would we be able to hire staff to lead vital ministries?
- Would we be able to have a climate controlled atmosphere?
- Would we be a great Missions church?

If the answer to any of these questions is no, then you are not pulling your weight in the body of Christ! You should start now!

CONCLUSION:

The great thing about tithing is that because it is based on ten percent of our income, **God is not looking for equal giving; He is looking for equal sacrifice!** **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE END OF SESSION)**

FACILITATOR'S QUESTIONS:

- 1) What is a tithe?
- 2) Who should tithe?
- 3) Where should one tithe?
- 4) Should one tithe off the net or gross?
- 5) Once the tithe is returned does the tither have a right to direct it?
- 6) What does the Word say about those who choose not to tithe?